♠ ♥ ♦ ♣ All Fives ♣ ♦ ♥ ♠

A natural, disciplined bidding system built on common sense.

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Philosophy

- **No crazy openings.** Bids mean what they look like.
- **Partner is reliable.** Trust his bids.
- **Use the opponents' information.**
- **Stay flexible.** This is an experimental system.
- **Most auctions are competitive.** Keep opening principles in mind.

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Known Problems

- **1** - 3rd/4th seat 1NT is 15-17 HCP (not 12-14), because a weak NT blocks us without a chance at game. 12-14 balanced hands open their 4-card suit directly (1♣ = 4+, 1♦/1♥/1♠ as available). RESOLVED (AMD-8 + DEC-6): prepared 1♣ eliminated. All 3rd/4th seat suit openings are real (4+). Forcing 1NT is OFF in 3rd/4th seat (responder is a passed hand). 1NT = natural, non-forcing.
- **2** - The 4441 distribution. Every system struggles with this.
- **3** - 1♥ and 1♠ usually promise 5, but may show only 4: (A) 15+ balanced with 4333 or 4-4 majors (any seat), (B) 12-14 balanced in 3rd/4th seat (can't open 1NT). Partner must be aware: after opener rebids 2NT (15-17) or a convenient minor (12-14), the opening suit may be only 4.
- **4** - New defensive bidding package (CRASH, Michaels, Lebensohl) is adopted but untested at the table. See H-7 for the effectiveness tracking plan.

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The Central Idea

Every 1-level suit opening promises 5+ cards, with known exceptions.

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Openings

1NT

1st/2nd seat: 12-14 HCP - shape 4333 / 4432 / 5332 (5332 includes a 5-card major).

3rd seat: 15-17 HCP - shape 4333 / 4432 / 5332.

Stronger range in 3rd seat. With a weak 12-14 hand we risk blocking ourselves from game when partner passed with 11. With 12-14 balanced, open a suit and plan a 1NT rebid (see below).

4th seat: 15-17 HCP - shape 4333 / 4432 / 5332.

** seat:** HCP.

Responses to 1NT

- **2♣** - Split Stayman - 4-card major ask (inv+)
- **2♦** - 5-card major ask (inv+, 8+ HCP)
- **2♥** - Natural, to play - weak hand with 5+ hearts
- **2♠** - Natural, to play - weak hand with 5+ spades
- **2NT** - Natural invitation (no 4M, no 5M)
- **3♣** - 5-5 minors, slam interest
- **3♦** - 5-5 majors, GF
- **3♥** - Splinter - short hearts, 5-4+ minors, slam interest
- **3♠** - Splinter - short spades, 5-4+ minors, slam interest

Split Stayman (2♣) Continuations

After 2♣, opener replies:

- **2♦** - No 4-card major (denial)
- **2♥** - 4+ hearts (may also have 4 spades)
- **2♠** - 4 spades, not 4 hearts

After 2♣ - 2♦ (no 4M), responder continues:

- **Pass** - Weak, no 4M - drop in 1NT
- **2♥** - Crawling Stayman - weak 4-4 majors. Opener passes (4♥) or corrects to 2♠ (4♠).
- **2NT** - Invitational, no 4-card major
- **3♥** - Smolen - 5♠ + 4♥, GF. Opener bids 3♠ with 3-card support, 3NT without.
- **3♠** - Smolen - 5♥ + 4♠, GF. Opener bids 4♥ with 3-card support, 3NT without.
- **3NT** - Game values, no 4-card major

Crawling Stayman (2♥ after denial): responder has weak 4-4 majors, wants to play in 2♥ or 2♠. Opener passes with 4♥, corrects to 2♠ with 4♠, or passes with neither (2♥ is the safer partscore). Smolen (3♥/3♠): shows 5 of the OTHER major + 4 of the bid major, GF. This right-sides 5-3 fits - opener declares from the strong side.

5-Card Major Ask (2♦) Continuations

After 2♦, opener replies:

- **2♥** - No 5-card major (artificial denial)
- **2♠** - 5 spades
- **2NT** - 5 hearts

After 2♦ - 2♥ (no 5M, artificial), responder continues:

- **Pass** - Weak (rare - usually uses natural 2♥/2♠ instead)
- **2♠** - Natural invite, 5+ spades
- **2NT** - Invitational, no fit

- **3NT** - Game values, no fit

After 2♦ - 2♠ (5 spades):

- **3♠** - Invite with spade support
- **4♠** - Game with spade support

After 2♦ - 2NT (5 hearts):

- **3♥** - Invite with heart support
- **4♥** - Game with heart support

Escaping 1NTx - Helvic Wriggle

After 1NT - (X):

- **XX** - One-suited hand. Opener bids 2♣, responder passes or corrects.
- **2♣** - ♣ + ♦ (touching pairs)
- **2♦** - ♦ + ♥ (touching pairs)
- **2♥** - ♥ + ♠ (touching pairs)
- **Pass** - To play, or will bid later

After Pass - Pass - **XX** = SOS with non-touching pairs (♣+♥ or ♦+♠). Opener bids 2♣, responder passes or corrects.

- **Weak, shapely** - Wriggle (escape to a suit fit)
- **Weak, balanced** - Pass (hope for the best)
- **Strong (10+ HCP)** - Pass - penalty. Thank them for doubling.

If opponents doubled, they show 15+ HCP. If responder has 10+, our side has 22+ combined - the opponents made a mistake. Pass and collect the penalty.

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1♣

1st/2nd seat: 12+ HCP, 4+ clubs. LTC: 7 losers typical (range 5-8).

Usually 5+, but may be 4 with 15+ balanced and 3-3-3-4 shape. A balanced 12-14 hand opens 1NT, so 1♣ with 12-14 is always 5+. The 4-card exception only applies to strong balanced hands (15+) where clubs is the longest suit. Opener rebids 2NT (15-17).

Example: *♠:A32 ♥:KJ3 ♦:Q32 ♣:AK54 (16 HCP) - Open 1♣ (3-3-3-4, 16 HCP). Rebid 2NT after any response.*

1♦

1st/2nd seat: 12+ HCP, 4+ diamonds. LTC: 7 losers typical (range 5-8).

Usually 5+, but may be 4 with 15+ balanced and no 5-card suit. This is the catch-all for strong balanced hands with 4+ diamonds and no 5-card major or club suit. Opener rebids 2NT (15-17).

Example: *♠:AQ43 ♥:KJ7 ♦:AQ32 ♣:43 (16 HCP) - Open 1♦ (4-3-4-2, 16 HCP). Rebid 2NT after any response.*

1♥

1st/2nd seat: 12+ HCP, 5+ hearts (usually). 4 with 4333 shape and 15+ HCP. LTC: 7 losers typical (range 5-8).

Usually 5+. The only exception: 3-4-3-3 with 15+ HCP. No minor has 4+ cards, so 1♥ is the only available opening. Rebid 2NT.

Example: *♠:Q32 ♥:AKJ3 ♦:AJ2 ♣:432 (15 HCP) - Open 1♥ (3-4-3-3, 15 HCP). Rebid 2NT - 15-17 balanced.*

1♠

1st/2nd seat: 12+ HCP, 5+ spades (usually). 4 with 4333 or 4-4 majors, 15+ HCP. LTC: 7 losers typical (range 5-8).

Usually 5+. Two exceptions: (A) 4-3-3-3 with 4 spades and 15+ HCP - no other suit to open. Rebid 2NT. (B) 4-4 majors, no 4+ minor (any seat) - open 1♠ to find hearts cheaply.

4-4 Majors - the 1♠ Solution (any seat)

With 4♠-4♥ and no 4+ minor, open 1♠ because after 1♠-1NT, bidding 2♥ is NOT a reverse (below 2♠). Opening 1♥ instead would require 3♠ to show spades - too high, forces game. Works in all seats: 1NT is forcing in 1st/2nd, natural in 3rd/4th - either way, 2♥ is cheap.

15 HCP → rebid **2♥**: Show 4 hearts cheaply. Not a reverse. Partner with 4 hearts raises. Partscore-range hand (15+6=21, 15+9=24).

♠:AQ43 ♥:KJ43 ♦:A32 ♣:43 (15 HCP): Open 1♠. After 1♠-1NT, bid 2♥.

16-17 HCP → rebid **2NT**: Show 15-17 balanced. Partner with 4 hearts and inv+ (10+) bids 3♥ - at 16+10=26, game is on. The 3-level is fine because you have the values.

♠:AQ43 ♥:KJ43 ♦:AK2 ♣:43 (17 HCP): Open 1♠. After 1♠-1NT, bid 2NT (game zone).

Opening Rules

- With two 5-card suits, open the higher one.
- With 5-4, open the 5-card suit.
- With 4-4 majors and a 4+ minor: open the minor, show majors naturally.
- With 4-4 majors, no 4+ minor (15 HCP 1st/2nd): open 1♠, rebid 2♥.
- With 4-4 majors, no 4+ minor (3rd/4th 12-14): open 1♣ (best minor).
- With 4-4 majors, no 4+ minor (1st/2nd 16-17): open 1♠, rebid 2NT.
- With 4-4 majors, no 4+ minor (3rd/4th 15-17): open 1NT.
- With 4333 and 15+ balanced: open the 4-card suit, rebid 2NT.
- A 2NT rebid after any opening confirms balanced (opening suit may be only 4).

3rd seat: 8+ HCP, 3+ clubs (best minor - may be short with balanced hand). SAYC-style best minor: 12-14 balanced hands open the longer minor. With 3-3 minors, open 1♣. With 4-4 majors and no 4+ minor, open 1♣ (best minor). 1♣ could be as short as 3 cards - responder should not jump-raise without 5+ support.

3rd seat: 8+ HCP, 3+ diamonds. Best minor: with longer diamonds than clubs, open 1♦. With 4-4 in both minors, open 1♦ (equal length, prefer diamonds per SAYC). With 3-3 minors, open 1♣. 1♦ can be as short as 3 (e.g., 4-4-3-2).

3rd seat: 8+ HCP, Strict 5+ cards. No 4-card balanced exceptions.. Unlike 1st/2nd seat, there are NO 4-card exceptions for majors in 3rd/4th. Balanced 12-14 hands open best minor, not a 4-card major. May be lighter HCP (passed-hand opening - tactical, competing for partscore and directing the lead).

Continuations

- **1x - 2x (single raise)** - 6-9 HCP, 3+ card support. Standard. If opener had only 4, he rebids 2NT. - 9-10 losers
- **1x - 3x (limit raise)** - 10-12 HCP, 4+ card support. Invitational. Opener bids game with 5-6 losers. - 7-8 losers
- **1M - 4M (game raise)** - Distributional, 5+ card support or strong hand. Based on playing tricks, not just HCP. - 6-7 losers

After a fit is found, re-evaluate using LTC: 24 minus combined losers = expected tricks. A hand with 10 HCP but 7 losers (e.g. ♠

:KQxxx ♥:x ♦:Axxx ♣:xxx) is a limit raise by LTC, though HCP says only a single raise. Trust LTC in suit contracts - see H-8.

Competitive Re-evaluation with LTC

When opponents intervene after our suit opening, both partners must re-evaluate using LTC, not just HCP. The auction (1♥) - 2♠ - ? asks responder: 'How many losers do I have in support of partner's suit?' A hand with 10 HCP and 9 losers should pass; a hand with 9 HCP and 7 losers should compete to 3♥.

- **Compete to the 2-level** - 16+ (8 tricks) - Free bid at the 2-level shows values; LTC confirms it's safe.
- **Compete to the 3-level** - 15 (9 tricks) - Law of Total Tricks applies here - with 9 trumps, bid to 3.
- **Bid game despite interference** - 14 or fewer (10+ tricks) - Don't let opponents push you out of game.
- **Double (penalty-oriented)** - - Prefer double when you hold 2+ defensive tricks and a misfit.

At favorable vulnerability, sacrifice when your combined LTC suggests you are outgunned. Going down 2 doubled non-vulnerable (-300) is better than letting them make game (+420/+620).

Sacrifice with 16+ combined losers at favorable; never at unfavorable.

1NT Response (Forcing)

6-12 HCP, FORCING one round. Forcing 1NT acknowledges that after a 5+ card opening, 1NT almost never survives as a final contract. Opener was going to bid again with 95% of hands anyway. DD simulation proved +1.118 tricks/deal over non-forcing (F-SIM-001, DEC-6).

Conditions:

- No fit (at most 3 cards in opener's suit)
- No new suit available at the 1-level
- 1st/2nd seat only (responder is an unpassed hand)
- OFF in 3rd/4th seat (responder is a passed hand - cannot force)

Competition: If opponents bid or double, 1NT is OFF (reverts to natural).

Seat rule: *Forcing 1NT is ON after all suit openings in 1st/2nd seat. OFF in 3rd/4th seat - responder is a passed hand and cannot force. 1NT = natural, non-forcing after 3rd/4th seat openings.*

Opener's Rebids After Forcing 1NT

Opener MUST bid again. Describe your hand naturally: show a second suit, rebid a long suit, or show balanced strength with 2NT. With a dead minimum 5-3-3-2 and no 4-card side suit, rebid the 5-card suit (this is rare - 0.4% of deals are "awkward").

After 1♥ - 1NT (forcing)

- **2♣** - 4+ clubs, any strength
- **2♦** - 4+ diamonds, any strength
- **2♥** - 6+ hearts, minimum (12-14)
- **2♠** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ spades (forcing)
- **2NT** - 15-17 balanced (confirms 4-card ♥ opening)
- **3♥** - 6+ hearts, invitational (15-17)

After 1♠ - 1NT (forcing)

- **2♣** - 4+ clubs, any strength
- **2♦** - 4+ diamonds, any strength
- **2♥** - 4+ hearts, any strength (NOT a reverse - below 2♠)
- **2♠** - 6+ spades, minimum (12-14)
- **2NT** - 15-17 balanced (confirms 4-card ♠ opening)
- **3♠** - 6+ spades, invitational (15-17)

After 1♦ - 1NT (forcing)

- **2♣** - 4+ clubs, any strength
- **2♦** - 6+ diamonds, minimum (12-14)
- **2♥** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ hearts (forcing)
- **2♠** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ spades (forcing)
- **2NT** - 15-17 balanced (confirms 4-card ♦ opening)
- **3♦** - 6+ diamonds, invitational (15-17)

After 1♣ - 1NT (forcing) - 1st/2nd seat

In 1st/2nd seat, 1♣ always promises 5+ clubs. A balanced 12-14 hand opens 1NT, not 1♣. So opener has a real club suit. This means a 4-card side major often stays hidden with minimum hands (can't reverse with only 12-15 HCP).

- **2♣** - 5-6 clubs, minimum (12-14), no 4-card side suit
- **2♦** - 4+ diamonds, real second suit (not a 'convenient' rebid - opener has 5♣-4♦+)
- **2♥** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ hearts (forcing)
- **2♠** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ spades (forcing)
- **2NT** - 15-17 balanced (why didn't you open 1NT? Because 5♣-3-3-2 with 15-17 - valid choice)
- **3♣** - 6+ clubs, invitational (15-17)

Responder's Second Bid After Forcing 1NT

After hearing opener's rebid, responder places the contract. With 6-9 HCP: pass. With 10-12 HCP: bid again (raise, preference, or 2NT). With a hidden 4-card major (after 1m): show it now.

Weak (6-9): Place the contract - usually pass, but correct with a long suit

- Pass opener's rebid (most hands)
- Bid your own 6+ card suit to play there (e.g. 1!S-1NT-2!C-2!H = weak, long hearts)
- Give preference back to opener's first suit with 2-card support

The goal is to find the best partscore, not just pass blindly. With a 6-card suit, playing in your suit beats a 2-level misfit. IMPORTANT: a new suit here is TO PLAY (weak), NOT invitational. Compare: 1♠ - 2♥ directly = 2/1 game force (10+ HCP). But 1♠ - 1NT(f) - 2♣ - 2♥ = weak with long hearts.

Invitational (10-12):

- Raise opener's second suit with 4+ support
- Give preference back to opener's first suit
- Bid 2NT with scattered values
- Raise to 3 of opener's rebid suit (invitational)

Hidden 4-card major: After 1-suit - 1NT(f) - rebid, responder has 4-card suit with inv+ values → Show the suit at the second turn

Responder's Decision Tree After Partner Opens 1-Suit

This is the practical guide: partner opens a suit, what do you bid? Work through the tree top to bottom. First match wins.

Step 1: Do you have a fit (3+ cards in partner's suit)?

- **Yes:** Raise directly. 2x = 6-9 HCP, 3x = 10-12 (limit raise), 4M = distributional game raise. Forcing 1NT does NOT apply.
- **No:** Continue to next question.

Step 2: Do you have a new suit to show at the 1-level?

- **Yes:** Bid it. In 1st/2nd seat: must be 5+ cards (DEC-6), except 1♣-1♦ = 4+. In 3rd/4th seat: 4+ cards (forcing 1NT is off, responder is a passed hand).
- **No:** Continue to next question.

Step 3: Do you have 6-12 HCP?

- **Yes:** In 1st/2nd seat: bid 1NT (forcing). Partner will describe their hand. With 6-9: pass whatever partner rebids. With 10-12: bid again. In 3rd/4th seat: 1NT = natural, non-forcing (6-10). Opener may pass.
- **No (too weak):** Pass (0-5 HCP).
- **No (too strong):** Bid 2/1 game force (13+ HCP).

Partner opens 1♥ (1st/2nd seat - forcing 1NT ON)

- **♠:Q43 ♥:K76 ♦:J432 ♣:J32** - 7 - 2♥ - fit (3 hearts), weak (6-9). Raise directly.
- **♠:Q43 ♥:K76 ♦:J432 ♣:A32** - 10 - 2♥ - fit (3 hearts), invitational. Still a single raise (not enough for limit raise without 4-card support).
- **♠:QJ432 ♥:K7 ♦:J43 ♣:932** - 7 - 1♠ - 5+ spades, show at 1-level.
- **♠:Q43 ♥:K7 ♦:J432 ♣:Q932** - 8 - 1NT (forcing) - no fit, no 5-card spade suit. Pass partner's rebid.
- **♠:QJ43 ♥:K7 ♦:A432 ♣:932** - 10 - 1NT (forcing) - 4 spades but not 5, can't bid 1♠. After partner's rebid, bid again to show invitational values.

Partner opens 1♣

- **♠:QJ43 ♥:K76 ♦:A432 ♣:93** - 10 - 1NT (forcing) - 4♠ but not 5, can't bid 1♠ (promises 5+). After partner rebids, show spades at the second turn (inv+).
- **♠:QJ432 ♥:K76 ♦:A43 ♣:93** - 10 - 1♠ - 5+ spades, bid at 1-level. This always promises 5+.
- **♠:K43 ♥:QJ43 ♦:J432 ♣:93** - 7 - 1NT (forcing) - 4♥ but not 5, no fit for clubs. Pass partner's rebid.
- **♠:K43 ♥:Q7 ♦:J432 ♣:9432** - 6 - 1NT (forcing) - no fit (only 4♣ is a fit, but that's marginal and we have no new suit at the 1-level). Pass rebid.

Partner opens 1♠

- **♠:K7 ♥:QJ432 ♦:J43 ♣:932** - 7 - 1NT (forcing) - 5♥ but can't bid at 1-level over 1♠. This is exactly why forcing 1NT helps over majors. Pass rebid.
- **♠:K7 ♥:QJ43 ♦:A432 ♣:932** - 10 - 1NT (forcing) - can't show hearts at 1-level. After partner's rebid, show hearts or bid 2NT (invitational).
- **♠:72 ♥:KJ8743 ♦:Q43 ♣:J2** - 7 - 1NT (forcing) - 6♥ but can't bid 2♥ directly (that's 2/1 GF, 10+ HCP). After partner rebids (say 2♣ or 2♦), bid 2♥ = weak, long hearts, TO PLAY. Not invitational!

Opener's view - hidden 4-card major after minor opening (1st/2nd seat)

- **♠:KJ43 ♥:Q7 ♦:32 ♣:AQ432** - 12 - Open 1♣. After 1♣ - 1NT(f), bid 2♣. Can't bid 2♠ (reverse = 16+). The 4♠ stays hidden - but partner with 5+ spades would have bid 1♠, so at worst we miss a 4-4 fit in a partscore.
- **♠:AQ43 ♥:K7 ♦:Q32 ♣:AJ43** - 16 - Open 1♣. After 1♣ - 1NT(f), bid 2♠ (reverse, 16+). With 16 HCP you CAN show the 4♠ - the reverse is correct.
- **♠:K7 ♥:A543 ♦:32 ♣:AQ432** - 13 - Open 1♣. After 1♣ - 1NT(f), bid 2♣. Can't bid 2♥ (reverse = 16+). 4♥ stays hidden. Same principle - partner with 5+ hearts would have bid 1♥.

Opener's view - 4-4 majors, no 4+ minor (1st/2nd seat)

- **♠:AQ43 ♥:KJ43 ♦:Q32 ♣:43** - 15 - Open 1♠ (4-4 majors, 15 HCP). After 1♠ - 1NT(f), bid 2♥ - shows 4 hearts cheaply (not a reverse). Partner with 4 hearts raises. With 15 HCP this is partscore zone.
- **♠:AQ43 ♥:KJ43 ♦:AQ2 ♣:43** - 17 - Open 1♠ (4-4 majors, 17 HCP). After 1♠ - 1NT(f), bid 2NT (15-17 balanced). At 17+8=25+ you're in game zone. Partner with 4 hearts and inv+ bids 3♥. 3-level is fine because you have the values.
- **♠:AQ43 ♥:KJ43 ♦:KQ2 ♣:43** - 16 - Open 1♠ (4-4 majors, 16 HCP). After 1♠ - 1NT(f), bid 2NT (16-17 balanced). Partner explores at the 3-level with inv+ values. With 16+10=26, game is on.

3rd/4th seat - 12-14 balanced (no prepared 1♣)

- **♠:KQ43 ♥:A76 ♦:QJ32 ♣:J3** - 13 - In 3rd seat: open 1♠ (4-card suit, 12-14 bal, can't open 1NT which is 15-17). After 1NT (natural, non-forcing from passed hand), rebid 2♦ (convenient minor). No forcing 1NT - partner is a passed hand.
- **♠:A76 ♥:K43 ♦:QJ32 ♣:Q32** - 12 - In 3rd seat: open 1♦ (4-card suit). After partner's response, rebid naturally. 1NT from partner is non-forcing.
- **♠:AQ43 ♥:KJ43 ♦:Q32 ♣:43** - 13 - In 3rd seat: open 1♠ (4-4 majors, no 4+ minor). After 1NT (natural, non-forcing), rebid 2♥ - shows 4 hearts cheaply.

3rd/4th seat - responder with 4 spades after 1♥

- **♠:QJ43 ♥:K7 ♦:A432 ♣:932** - 10 - Partner opens 1♥ in 3rd seat. Bid 1♠ - 4+ spades is fine (forcing 1NT is off, no '5+ always' rule in 3rd/4th seat).
- **♠:QJ43 ♥:K7 ♦:J432 ♣:932** - 7 - Partner opens 1♥ in 3rd seat. Bid 1♠ - same rule, 4+ spades. In 1st/2nd seat this hand would bid 1NT (forcing) because 1♠ requires 5+. But here it's natural.

Opener's rebids after 1♣ - 1♥ (1st/2nd seat)

- **1♠** - 4+ spades, any strength (not a reverse - still at the 1-level)
- **1NT** - 15-17 HCP, balanced (5♣-3-3-2 that chose 1♣ over 1NT)
- **2♣** - 5-6 clubs, minimum (12-14)
- **2♦** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ ♦ (forcing)
- **2♥** - Simple raise - 3+ ♥ support
- **2♠** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ ♠ (forcing)
- **2NT** - 18-19 HCP, balanced
- **3♣** - 6+ clubs, invitational (15-17)

Quick Reference

- **1♣ - 1♦** - Natural, 4+ diamonds, waiting
- **1♣ - 1♥/♠** - Always 5+ (DEC-6). 4-card major inv+ routes through 1NT forcing.

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2♣ - Semi-Strong (Benji)

Type 1 - Balanced

22-23 HCP: 2♣ - 2♦ - 2NT

Type 2 - Strong Major (Acol-style)

2♣ - 2♦ - 2♥/♠

- About 5 losers
- At least 5 cards in the suit (usually 6+)
- At least 3 top honours (A, K, Q)
- Partner needs roughly 2 fillers to make game

Type 3 - Strong Two-Suiter

2♣ - 2♦ - 3♣/3♦/3♥/3♠/3NT

After 2♣-2♦ (waiting), opener's 3-level rebid shows a strong two-suiter. Five rebids cover all suit combinations: 3♣ = clubs + any suit (relay to identify), 3♦ = diamonds + a major, 3♥ = both majors (known), 3♠ = 4♠ + 6+ minor (4-6 shape), 3NT = 4♥ + 6+ minor (4-6 shape).

Responses to 2♣

- **2♦** - Waiting (0-7 HCP)
- **2♥** - Positive relay - balanced, no 5-card suit, 8+ HCP
- **2♠** - 5+ spades, 8+ HCP
- **2NT** - 5+ hearts, 8+ HCP
- **3♣ / 3♦** - 5+ clubs/diamonds, game-force, slam interest opposite 22-23

All non-2♦ responses are game-forcing (8+ HCP). This avoids the problem where after 2♣ - 2♦ - 2♥, responder cannot show a 5-card major.

2♦ - Strong Game-Force

LTC: 3-4 losers (game in hand or near it)

Responder shows **controls** (Controls (Ace = 2, King = 1)):

- **2♥** - 0-1
- **2♠** - 2
- **2NT** - 3
- **3♣** - 4
- **3♦** - 5
- **3♥** - 6

Excellent for slam exploration. Opener immediately knows the combined control count and can place the contract or ask further.

2♥ / 2♠ - Weak Two

6-10 HCP, 6+ cards. Disciplined, especially when vulnerable. LTC: 8-9 losers.

Suit quality: At least 2 of the top 5 honours (A, K, Q, J, T).

- 6+ cards in the bid major
- 6-10 HCP (not less, not more)
- Decent suit quality - partner may raise pre-emptively or try for game
- Avoid opening a weak two with a void or a strong 4-card side suit

Ogust (2NT asks) - __

2NT - 20-21 HCP

Shape: 4333 / 4432 / 5332.

Responses to 2NT

- **3♣** - Puppet Stayman - asks for 5-card major
- **3♦** - Transfer to ♥
- **3♥** - Transfer to ♠
- **4NT** - Quantitative (inviting 6NT)

After 3♣, opener replies: 3♦ = denies 5-card major, then check for 4-card fits, 3♥ = 5 hearts, 3♠ = 5 spades.

Puppet Stayman fits better over 2NT than 1NT: the auction is already at the 3-level, so information leakage matters less, and finding the right major-suit game matters more.

3-level and Above

- **3♣ / 3♦ / 3♥ / 3♠** - Preemptive - Destructive block. Sound at unfavourable vulnerability., 7+ cards, ~5-10 HCP, LTC: 7-8 losers (favorable: 8-9; unfavorable: 7)
- **3NT** - UCM Shape - Two same-shape suits (♠♦ pointed or ♥♣ rounded), 5-5+, ≤3 losers
- **4♣** - UCM Color - Two same-color suits (♥♦ red or ♠♣ black), 5-5+, ≤3 losers
- **4♦** - UCM Rank - Two same-rank suits (♠♥ majors or ♣♦ minors), 5-5+, ≤3 losers
- **4♥ / 4♠** - To play - strong distributional hand or preemptive
- **5♣ / 5♦** - Extreme preempt or to play

Defensive Bidding

Vulnerability-Adjusted Losing Trick Count

All defensive bidding actions are governed by Losing Trick Count (LTC) adjusted for vulnerability. HCP gives a rough guide, but LTC measures offensive potential - the number of tricks your hand can contribute. Vulnerability determines how aggressive you can afford to be:

cheap penalties at favorable allow lighter action; expensive penalties at unfavorable demand discipline.

- **Favorable** - We are Not Vulnerable, they are Vulnerable (NV vs Vul)
- **Equal** - Both Vulnerable or both Not Vulnerable
- **Unfavorable** - We are Vulnerable, they are Not Vulnerable (Vul vs NV)

At favorable vulnerability, act with 1 more loser than standard (the penalty for going down is cheap: 50/trick undoubled). At unfavorable vulnerability, require 1 fewer loser than standard (the penalty is expensive: 100/trick undoubled, 200+ doubled). At equal vulnerability, use standard thresholds.

LTC Reference Table

- **Simple overcall** - 9 losers - 8 losers - 7 losers
- **Jump overcall (weak)** - 10 losers - 9 losers - 8 losers
- **Takeout double** - 7 losers - 6 losers - 5 losers
- **CRASH / CRASH vs 1NT** - 9 losers, 5-4+ shape - 8 losers, 5-4+ shape - 7 losers, 5-5+ shape
- **Michaels / Unusual 2NT** - 9 losers (weak side) - 8 losers (weak side) - 7 losers or 16+ HCP (strong side only)
- **RAPTOR 1NT overcall** - 9 losers - 8 losers - 7 losers
- **Natural overcall at 2-level** - 8 losers - 7 losers - 6 losers

Overcalls

- **Simple overcall** - 8-16 HCP, 5++ cards. Suit quality matters more than HCP. A 5-card suit headed by two honours with 8 losers is a sound overcall. Assess tricks, not points. LTC: 8 losers at equal; 9 at favorable; 7 at unfavorable.
- **Jump overcall** - Weak - same as a weak two/three opening at the appropriate level - same as a weak two/three opening at the appropriate level. LTC: 9 losers at equal; 10 at favorable; 8 at unfavorable.
- **Takeout double** - Support for all unbid suits, typically 12+ HCP or any 17+. LTC: 6 losers at equal (shape compensates for fewer HCP with good support).

RAPTOR Convention

An overcall of **1NT** over opponent's suit opening shows:

- **4 cards in the unbid major**
- **5+ cards in a minor**
- **10-16 HCP**

We bid using the **minimax principle** (minimax - aiming to sign off, tolerate a suit). Comes up more frequently than a natural 1NT (15-17) overcall. The HCP range is 10-16 because lighter hands pass and stronger hands start with a takeout double. LTC is more accurate than HCP here because the 4-5+ two-suited shape generates tricks.

After Opponent Opens 1♥ or 1♠

Shows: 4 in unbid major + 5+ in a minor.

- **Cue bid (opponent's suit)** - Asks for the major
- **2 of other minor** - To play
- **2 of unbid major** - Natural, 5+ cards, willing to play
- **2NT** - Invitational+, asks overcaller's shape

After Opponent Opens 1♣ or 1♦

Shows: 5+ in other minor + 4 in an unknown major.

- **2♣ (cheapest minor)** - Pass or correct to overcaller's minor
- **Cue bid (opponent's suit)** - Asks for the major
- **2♥ / 2♠** - Natural, 5+ cards
- **2NT** - Invitational+, asks overcaller's shape

CRASH Convention

Trigger: Opponents open artificial/strong bid or short/garbage suit (strong 1♣, 2♣, 2♦, short ♣ 2+, garbage 1♦). NOT against Multi 2♦ - use natural bidding instead.

When opponents open an artificial/strong bid that does not promise a specific suit, all four suits are 'unbid'. CRASH provides three two-suited bids organized by suit-pairing property: Color, Rank, Shape. The same applies to garbage/short openings where the bid does not promise length in the suit.

- **Color** - Two same-color suits (♥+♦ reds, or ♠+♣ blacks)
- **Rank** - Two same-rank suits (♥+♠ majors, or ♣+♦ minors)
- **Shape** - Two same-shape suits (♠+♦ pointed, or ♥+♣ rounded)
- 5-4+ shape (5-5+ required at unfavorable vulnerability)
- LTC: 8 losers at equal, 9 at favorable, 7 at unfavorable
- At unfavorable: only act with 5-5+ shape and 7 or fewer losers
- At favorable: 5-4 shape with 9 losers is acceptable - disruption value is high

vs Strong 2♣: (2♣) - ?

- **X** - Color (reds or blacks)
- **2♦** - Rank (majors or minors)
- **2♥** - Natural, 5+ hearts
- **2♠** - Natural, 5+ spades
- **2NT** - Shape (pointed or rounded)

vs Strong 1♣: (1♣) - ?

- **X** - Color (reds or blacks)
- **1♦** - Rank (majors or minors)
- **1♥** - Natural, 5+ hearts
- **1♠** - Natural, 5+ spades
- **1NT** - Shape (pointed or rounded)

vs Strong / Garbage 2♦: (2♦) - ? [strong or garbage 2♦ only - NOT Multi 2♦]

- **X** - Color (reds or blacks)
- **2♥** - Rank (majors or minors)
- **2♠** - Natural, 5+ spades
- **2NT** - Shape (pointed or rounded)

vs Garbage / Short 1♦: (1♦) - ? [garbage/short ♦, does not promise length]

- **X** - Color (reds or blacks)
- **1♥** - Rank (majors or minors)
- **1♠** - Natural, 5+ spades
- **1NT** - Shape (pointed or rounded)

Advancer (partner of CRASH bidder)

Advancer uses pass/correct to find the right suit. Bid your better suit in the shorter possible pair. If you hold equal preference, bid the cheaper suit.

- **Partner bids Color (reds or blacks), you hold ♥:Kxxx ♦:xx ♠:Jxx ♣:xxxx** → Bid hearts (your better red suit). If partner has blacks, he corrects to ♠.
- **Partner bids Rank (majors or minors), you hold ♥:xx ♠:Qxxx ♣:Kxxxx ♦:x** → Bid ♠ (your better major). If partner has minors, he corrects to his minor.

CRASH Defense to 1NT (differentiated by strength)

Unified CRASH framework extends to 1NT defense. Against weak NT, a penalty double is too valuable to sacrifice (opponents are minimum, conversion is frequent). Against strong NT, disruption via CRASH is more productive than penalty. After a penalty double, if opponents run, revert to natural bidding.

Vs Strong NT (15-17)

Trigger: (1NT: 15-17) - ?

- **X** - Color (reds or blacks)
- **2♣** - Rank (majors or minors)
- **2♦** - Shape (pointed or rounded)
- **2♥** - Natural, 5+ hearts
- **2♠** - Natural, 5+ spades

Pure CRASH. No penalty double - against 15-17, we are unlikely to have a big penalty. Disruption and lead direction are more valuable.

Vs Weak NT (12-14)

Trigger: (1NT: 12-14) - ?

- **X** - Penalty (15+ HCP)
- **2♣** - Color (reds or blacks)
- **2♦** - Rank (majors or minors)
- **2♥** - Natural, 5+ hearts
- **2♠** - Natural, 5+ spades
- **2NT** - Shape (pointed or rounded)

CRASH shifts one step up to make room for penalty double. Shape moves to 2NT. Against 12-14, the penalty double is high-frequency and lucrative - opponents are minimum and unlikely to make 1NT doubled.

After penalty double: Natural bidding resumes. No CRASH, no special meanings.

- - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - -

Michaels Cuebid

Trigger: Direct cuebid of opponent's natural suit opening

Over Minor: (1♣) - 2♣ or (1♦) - 2♦

Shows: Both majors (5-5+)

- **2♥ / 2♠** - To play (preference)
- **2NT** - Asks for minor; game interest
- **3♥ / 3♠** - Invitational (4+ card support)
- **4♥ / 4♠** - To play

Over Major: (1♥) - 2♥ or (1♠) - 2♠

Shows: Other major + unspecified minor (5-5+)

- **2♠ (or 2♥)** - To play in the other major
- **2NT** - Asks which minor (3♣ = clubs, 3♦ = diamonds)
- **3♣** - Pass or correct (to play in overcaller's minor)
- **3 of other major** - Invitational
- **4 of other major** - To play

Unusual 2NT

Trigger: Jump to 2NT over opponent's 1-level suit opening

Shows: Two lowest unbid suits (5-5+)

Range: Same as Michaels: weak (8-9 losers) or strong (5-6 losers)

Lebensohl

Trigger: Partner doubles opponent's weak two (2♥ or 2♠) for takeout

Without Lebensohl, advancer cannot distinguish weak (0-7), invitational (8-11), and game-forcing (12+) hands. The 2NT relay creates a weak channel; direct bids become constructive. Slow Shows, Fast Denies resolves the 3NT stopper question.

- **Weak (0-7 HCP, 10+ losers)** - Bid 2NT relay → pass or correct at 3-level
- **Invitational (8-11 HCP, 8-9 losers)** - Bid directly at 3-level (natural, non-forcing)
- **Game-forcing (12+ HCP, 7 or fewer losers)** - Cuebid or direct 3NT
- **Penalty (any HCP, 5+ strong trumps in opponent's suit)** - Pass (penalty conversion). Partner leads a trump.

- **2NT** - Relay to 3♣ (weak hand, 0-7 HCP, 10+ losers)
- → **doubler: 3♣** - Forced relay
- → **advancer: Pass / 3♦ / 3♥** - Pass or correct to play in advancer's suit
- **direct 3-level suit** - Invitational (8-11 HCP), natural, non-forcing
- **cuebid (3 of their suit)** - Game-forcing, asks for stopper in opponent's suit
- **direct 3NT** - To play, denies stopper in their suit (Fast Denies)
- **2NT then 3NT (after relay)** - To play, shows stopper in their suit (Slow Shows)

- **Pass** - Penalty conversion - 5+ strong trumps (2+ of AKQ) in opponent's suit. Partner leads a trump.

'Slow Shows, Fast Denies' - going through the 2NT relay before bidding 3NT shows a stopper (you took the slow route). Bidding 3NT directly denies a stopper (fast route). This lets partner judge whether 3NT or a suit game is better.

Defense to Multi 2♦ (Fighters style)

Trigger: (2♦) - ? [Multi 2♦ - weak two in either major, 5-10 HCP, 6-card major]

Multi 2♦ is PREEMPTIVE, not artificial/strong. CRASH is explicitly excluded (simulation: 46.9% MP, 0.8:1 gain/loss across 40,000 deals). The key problem is ambiguity - which major do they have? The Fighters defense acts minimally in direct seat, then uses pass-then-act to compete once the suit is revealed.

CRASH excluded: *CRASH was falsified against Multi 2♦ by DD simulation. The opener is weak (5-10 HCP) with a known 6-card major, so CRASH's suit-pairing disruption adds no value. Our side typically holds 20-25 HCP - the goal is to reach the right contract, not to disrupt. See contract-bridge/simulation/crash.md.*

Direct Seat Actions (immediately over 2♦)

- **X** - Fighters double: 12-15 HCP balanced, OR any 19+ HCP
- **2♥** - Natural, 5+ hearts, 10+ HCP, good suit
- **2♠** - Natural, 5+ spades, 10+ HCP, good suit
- **2NT** - 16-18 HCP balanced (systems on - Puppet Stayman, transfers)
- **3♣** - Natural, good 6+ suit, constructive (opening values)
- **3♦** - Natural, good 6+ suit, constructive (opening values)
- **3♥** - Natural, good 6+ suit, constructive (opening values)
- **3♠** - Natural, good 6+ suit, constructive (opening values)
- **Pass** - Default - most hands. Wait for suit to be revealed.

Phase 2 - After Opponent's Suit Is Revealed

Trigger: (2♦) - Pass - 2♥/2♠ (pass or correct) - ?

Once the suit is known, treat exactly as defense to a standard weak two. Lebensohl applies (R-BID-021, F-SYS-018). This is the primary advantage of pass-then-act: no new convention needed, existing Lebensohl covers it.

- **X** - Takeout of the revealed major
- **2NT** - Lebensohl relay to 3♣ (weak hand, pass or correct)
- **direct 3-level suit** - Invitational (8-11 HCP), natural, non-forcing
- **cuebid (3 of their suit)** - Game-forcing, asks stopper
- **direct 3NT** - To play (Fast Denies stopper)
- **2NT then 3NT** - To play (Slow Shows stopper)

Examples

- **Multi 2♦, you hold ♠:AQ43 ♥:K52 ♦:J76 ♣:A32 (14 HCP balanced)** → Double (12-15 balanced). Partner places contract.
- **Multi 2♦, you hold ♠:AKQ2 ♥:AK4 ♦:KJ6 ♣:Q32 (22 HCP)** → Double (19+). You will bid again strongly after partner's response.
- **Multi 2♦, you hold ♠:KQJ84 ♥:A3 ♦:72 ♣:KJ54 (14 HCP)** → 2♠ natural (5+ spades, 10+ HCP). Lead-directing and constructive.
- **Multi 2♦ - Pass - 2♥, you hold ♠:AK32 ♥:52 ♦:KJ76 ♣:A32** → Double (takeout of hearts). Lebensohl applies - partner bids naturally.

Defense to 5-5 Openings

Trigger: (2♥) = 5♥ + 5-card minor, or (2♠) = 5♠ + 5-card minor

The bid major is known - treat as a weak two in that major. Standard weak-two defense applies: double = takeout, Lebensohl structures responses. The only additional awareness: opener has a 5-card minor, so bid minors cautiously (prefer the longer minor when advancer has a choice between two).

- **X** - Takeout of the bid major. Lebensohl applies.
- **2NT** - 16-18 HCP balanced (systems on - Puppet Stayman, transfers)
- **new suit** - Natural, constructive (opening values)
- **cuebid (3♥ over 2♥, 3♠ over 2♠)** - Game-forcing, stopper ask
- **3NT** - To play, with stopper(s)

Opener has a 5-card minor. If advancer is choosing between clubs and diamonds, prefer the longer one. If equal length, prefer the one less likely to be opener's second suit (often unknowable - just bid your longer/stronger minor).

Examples

- **(2♥ = 5♥ + 5m), you hold ♠:KQ43 ♥:52 ♦:AJ76 ♣:K32** → Double (takeout of hearts). Lebensohl applies if needed.
- **(2♠ = 5♠ + 5m), you hold ♠:72 ♥:AKJ84 ♦:Q3 ♣:KJ54** → 3♥ natural, constructive (good 5-card suit, opening values).

Defense to 3-Level Preempts

Trigger: Opponent opens 3♣ / 3♦ / 3♥ / 3♠

At the 3-level, double is takeout/cooperative - partner should bid with shape and pass with flat defence. New suits at the 3-level are forcing. Lebensohl does NOT apply (already at the 3-level, no 2NT relay available).

- **X** - Takeout/cooperative - asks partner to bid with shape, pass with flat defence
- **3NT** - To play (requires stopper in their suit)
- **new suit at 3-level** - Forcing, natural, good suit
- **new suit at 4-level** - To play (not forcing)
- **4NT** - Unusual - two lowest unbid suits

Against major preempts, the cooperative double is the key tool - "do something intelligent." Against minor preempts, there is more room to bid naturally.

Examples

- **(3♥), you hold ♠:AQ43 ♥:52 ♦:KJ76 ♣:A32 (14 HCP, short hearts)** → Double (takeout). Partner bids best suit.
- **(3♦), you hold ♠:KQ2 ♥:AJ4 ♦:QJ76 ♣:K32 (16 HCP, diamond stopper)** → 3NT to play.
- **(3♣), you hold ♠:72 ♥:AKJ843 ♦:KQ3 ♣:54 (13 HCP, good suit)** → 3♥ forcing - natural, good suit.

Defense to 4-Level Preempts

Trigger: Opponent opens 4♣ / 4♦ / 4♥ / 4♠

The key rule: double of a major preempt at game level = penalty-oriented (partner passes unless very distributional). Double of a minor preempt below game = takeout (room to find a major fit).

- **X of 4♥ / 4♠** - Penalty-oriented (partner passes unless very distributional)

- **X of 4♣ / 4♦** - Takeout (room to find major fit below game)
- **4NT over 4♥ / 4♠** - Two-suited takeout (both minors, or any 5-5+)
- **5-level** - To play

Examples

- **(4♠), you hold ♠:KJ4 ♥:AQ7 ♦:K983 ♣:A52 (17 HCP, balanced)** → Double (penalty). Expect to defeat 4♠.
- **(4♦), you hold ♠:AQ43 ♥:KJ76 ♦:2 ♣:AJ32 (15 HCP, short diamonds)** → Double (takeout). Partner bids best major.
- **(4♥), you hold ♠:32 ♥: - ♦:KQJ876 ♣:AQJ54 (extreme shape)** → 4NT (two-suited takeout). Both minors.

Balancing (Protection)

Trigger: Opponent's bidding dies at a low level - (1x) - P - P - ? or (1x) - P - (2x) - P - P - ?

When opponents stop low, partner's pass may trap values behind the opener ("borrowing a king from partner"). Act with ~3 HCP less than a direct action. Critical at matchpoints - letting opponents play undisturbed at the 1-2 level is often a bottom board.

- **Balancing 1NT** - ~11-14 HCP (not 15-18 like direct seat)
- **Balancing takeout double** - 10+ HCP (not 12+ like direct seat)
- **Balancing overcall** - 8+ HCP, reasonable suit
- **Balancing jump overcall** - Intermediate (not weak - partner already passed)

Partner must downgrade by ~3 HCP when responding to a balancing action ("return the borrowed king"). Do not jump to game when partner balances unless your hand justifies it independently.

Examples

- **(1♠) - Pass - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:52 ♥:KJ43 ♦:A76 ♣:Q832 (10 HCP)** → Double (balancing takeout). Would pass in direct seat (too weak for direct X).
- **(1♥) - Pass - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:KQ4 ♥:J76 ♦:AJ32 ♣:Q54 (13 HCP)** → 1NT (balancing, shows ~11-14). Not strong enough for direct 1NT (15-18).
- **(1♦) - Pass - (2♦) - Pass - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:AJ84 ♥:K43 ♦:72 ♣:Q832** → Double (balancing). Partner's pass trapped values.

Advancing Partner's Overcall

Trigger: (1x) - 1y/2y [partner overcalls] - Pass/Bid - ?

Key insight: cuebid = good raise, jump raise = weak. This reverses what many club players assume. Simple raise is competitive (Law of Total Tricks), not invitational. New suits are non-forcing.

- **simple raise** - Competitive, 6-9 HCP, 3+ support (Law of Total Tricks, not invitational)
- **cuebid of opponent's suit** - Limit raise or better (10+ HCP, 3+ support)
- **jump raise** - Preemptive (weak, 4+ support - NOT invitational)
- **2NT** - Sound constructive raise (9-11 HCP, 3+ support, balanced)
- **new suit** - Non-forcing (constructive, but may be passed)
- **jump in new suit** - Fit-showing (good suit + support for partner, invitational)

Examples

- **(1♥) - 1♠ - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:Q43 ♥:72 ♦:KJ76 ♣:8432 (6 HCP)** → 2♠ (simple raise, competitive - not invitational).
- **(1♥) - 1♠ - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:K43 ♥:72 ♦:AJ76 ♣:K432 (11 HCP)** → 2♥ (cuebid = limit raise+). Shows 10+ with spade support.
- **(1♥) - 1♠ - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:QJ43 ♥:2 ♦:J9763 ♣:843 (4 HCP)** → 3♠ (jump raise = preemptive, 4 trumps, weak).
- **(1♦) - 1♠ - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:K3 ♥:AQ984 ♦:76 ♣:J543 (10 HCP)** → 2♥ (new suit, non-forcing). Constructive but partner may pass.

Advancing Partner's Takeout Double (of 1-Level)

Trigger: (1x) - X - Pass - ?

The most common use of a takeout double. Partner has asked you to bid - you MUST bid unless you want to convert to penalty. Lebensohl covers responses to doubles of weak twos (see Lebensohl section). This section covers responses to doubles of 1-level openings.

- **cheapest 4-card suit** - Minimum (0-8 HCP) - forced, even with nothing
- **jump in a suit** - Invitational (9-11 HCP), shows real values and 4+ cards
- **cuebid of opener's suit** - Game force (12+ HCP), no clear direction - asks doubler to describe
- **1NT** - 6-10 HCP with stopper in opener's suit
- **2NT** - 11-12 HCP with stopper in opener's suit (invitational)
- **Pass** - Penalty conversion (rare - requires 5+ strong trumps in opener's suit)

The penalty pass is a powerful but rare weapon. Requirements: 5+ cards in opener's suit with good honours (e.g., KQJ9x). Partner must lead a trump. Do NOT pass just because you have nothing - bid your cheapest suit instead.

Examples

- **(1♥) - X - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:J743 ♥:852 ♦:964 ♣:932 (1 HCP)** → 1♠ (cheapest 4-card suit). Forced - even with nothing.
- **(1♥) - X - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:KQ43 ♥:52 ♦:A76 ♣:J832 (10 HCP)** → 2♠ (jump = invitational, shows 9-11 and 4+ spades).
- **(1♦) - X - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:A43 ♥:KJ6 ♦:Q74 ♣:K832 (13 HCP)** → 2♦ (cuebid = game force). Asks partner to describe further.
- **(1♥) - X - Pass - ?, you hold ♠:43 ♥:KQJ97 ♦:864 ♣:Q32 (8 HCP)** → Pass (penalty conversion). Strong trumps; partner leads a trump.

Lead-Directing Doubles of Artificial Bids

Trigger: Opponents make an artificial bid (Stayman, transfer, cuebid, slam)

One principle covers all cases: double of an artificial bid always requests a lead of that suit. This is free information at zero memory cost.

- **X of Stayman (2♣)** - Lead clubs
- **X of transfer (2♦ over 1NT)** - Lead diamonds (the suit doubled, not the target major)
- **X of transfer (2♥ over 1NT)** - Lead hearts (the suit doubled, not the target major)
- **X of any cuebid** - Lead the cuebid suit
- **X of voluntarily-bid slam** - Lightner double - unusual lead request (NOT your normal lead)

Lightner double requests the most unusual lead: typically dummy's first-bid suit, or a suit where you can ruff. It explicitly says "do NOT lead the normal suit (our suit, or the unbid suit)."

Examples

- **(1NT) - Pass - (2♣ Stayman) - X** → Lead clubs. You hold ♣:KQJ84 or similar.
- **(1NT) - Pass - (2♦ transfer) - X** → Lead diamonds. You hold ♦:AKJ or good diamonds.
- **Opponents bid 6♠ voluntarily, you double (Lightner)** → Partner leads dummy's first-bid suit (or the most unusual suit).

Defense to Opponents' Transfers over Their 1NT

Trigger: (1NT) - Pass - (2♦/2♥ transfer) - ?

Extends the lead-directing double principle. Generally be conservative - opponents have announced combined 20+ HCP. Only compete with shape or strength.

- **X of transfer** - Lead-directing - shows the suit being doubled (not the target major)
- **bid of transfer suit** - Natural - you hold that suit (e.g., 2♦ over 2♦ shows diamonds)
- **bid of target suit** - Takeout/lead-directing (showing the other suits)

Examples

- **(1NT) - Pass - (2♦ = transfer to ♥) - X** → Shows diamonds (lead-directing). Bid 2♥ if you have hearts (natural).
- **(1NT) - Pass - (2♥ = transfer to ♠) - 2♠** → Takeout of spades (the target suit). Showing the other suits.

Sandwich Position

Trigger: (1x) - Pass - (1y) - ? [sitting between two bidding opponents]

Acting between two bidding opponents is dangerous - both have values. Be cautious. The key agreement: 1NT in the sandwich position is UNUSUAL (showing the two lower unbid suits), NOT natural. Only act with real shape or real strength.

- **X** - Both unbid suits, moderate values (at least opening count)
- **1NT** - Unusual - two lower unbid suits (NOT natural)
- **overcall** - Natural, good suit required (sandwiched between two bidders)

The sandwich position is the most dangerous position at the table. Both opponents have values, and partner is broke. Only act with extreme shape (5-5+) or genuine strength. Light actions here produce catastrophic results.

Examples

- **(1♣) - Pass - (1♥) - ?, you hold ♠:KQ43 ♥:2 ♦:AQJ76 ♣:843** → 1NT (unusual - shows diamonds + spades, the two lower unbid).
- **(1♦) - Pass - (1♠) - ?, you hold ♠:72 ♥:AKJ84 ♦:Q3 ♣:KJ54** → 2♥ (overcall, good suit). Dangerous position but suit quality justifies.

- - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - -

Defensive Carding

Use your head first, not partner's signals. In most situations, the bidding and dummy tell you everything. Signals are a last resort.

Three-Axis Signal Protocol

After dummy appears, choose signal type using three axes. This is mechanical, not creative. Declarer reads your signals too - factor in adversarial cost.

1. Attitude (Encourage / Discourage) (Encourage / Discourage)

- **Low card (2, 3, 4)** - Encouraging - I have values here, continue this suit
- **High card (7, 8, 9)** - Discouraging - I have nothing here, please switch

2. Count (Even / Odd) (Even / Odd)

- **High card (8, 7, 6)** - Even number of cards (2 or 4)
- **Low card (2, 3, 4)** - Odd number of cards (3 or 5)

Reverse Smith Echo (vs NT only)

Information: 1.0 bit of delayed cross-suit attitude

Adversarial cost: FREE - signal in declarer's suit about the led suit

- **Low card in declarer's suit** - I LIKE the opening lead suit - continue it when you get in
- **High card in declarer's suit** - I DON'T LIKE the opening lead suit - switch when you get in

Exception: *When dummy has an entryless long suit threatening to run, count overrides Smith Echo. Partner needs to know WHEN to win, not WHETHER to continue.*

Examples

- **Partner led ♠5 vs 3NT. Declarer won ♠A. Declarer now leads ♥Q.** - → Play ♥4 (LOW = like spades - you have ♠KJ83)
- **Partner led ♠5 vs 3NT. Declarer won ♠A. Declarer now leads ♥Q.** - → Play ♥7 (HIGH = don't like spades - you have only ♠92)
- **Partner led ♦7 vs 3NT. Declarer won ♦A. Declarer leads ♣K.** - → Play ♣2 (LOW = like diamonds - you have ♦QJ sitting behind declarer's ♦A)
- **Partner led ♥4 vs 3NT. Dummy: ♥3, ♦AKQJ73 (no side entry).** - → DO NOT play Smith. Give COUNT instead (♦8 = even). Partner needs to know when to win the diamond stopper, not whether to continue hearts.

Reverse Smith (low = like). Matches our attitude convention. Near-mandatory at expert level.

Trump Suit Preference (TSP)

- **High-low in trumps (e.g., ♠8 then ♠4)** - I want the HIGHER-ranking side suit led
- **Low-high in trumps (e.g., ♠4 then ♠8)** - I want the LOWER-ranking side suit led

Caution: *NEVER signal with potential trump tricks. If you hold Qxx or Jxx of trumps, just follow low - keep your honor guarded. The signal MUST NOT cost a trick. Safety first, information second.*

3. Suit Preference on Discards (Italian Style) on Discards

- **Odd card (3, 5, 7, 9)** - I WANT this suit led - I have values here
- **Low even card (2, 4)** - I DON'T want this suit. Lead the LOWER remaining suit.
- **High even card (6, 8)** - I DON'T want this suit. Lead the HIGHER remaining suit.

The higher the discard, the less reliable (you might need that card). The second discard confirms.

Discard Discipline - Four Iron Rules

4. Opening Leads

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Dummy Analysis - Systematic Defense from Trick 1

Every defensive decision flows from two questions: (1) How many tricks can declarer take if I do nothing? (2) Can I do something about it? If declarer has enough tricks → ACTIVE defence (race to cash, attack, switch). If declarer is short → PASSIVE defence (don't help, make declarer work). The dummy taxonomy and bidding reconstruction ANSWER these questions.

Dummy Suit Taxonomy

Every suit in dummy falls into one of five categories. Classify all four suits before playing to trick 1. The classification drives your entire defence plan.

RUNNING THREAT: 5+ cards with 3+ honours or solid sequence (e.g., AKQxx, KQJ9x, AQJ10x, KQJ74)

- Defence: RACE or CUT. Either cash your winners before this suit runs (active), or attack entries so declarer can never reach it (entry attack).
- *Example*: Dummy: ♠754 ♥Q862 ♦KQJ93 ♣5 → Diamonds are a RUNNING THREAT (5 cards, KQJ). If declarer has ♦A, that's 5 tricks. Race to cash or cut diamond entries.

ESTABLISHABLE SOURCE: 4+ cards with 1-2 honours - needs development (e.g., KJ84, Q10753, A8642, K9743)

- Defence: HOLD UP or ATTACK ENTRIES. Duck the first round to exhaust declarer's communication. If dummy has limited side entries, the suit dies on the vine.
- *Example*: Dummy: ♠Q4 ♥K63 ♦J10742 ♣852 → Diamonds are an ESTABLISHABLE SOURCE (5 cards, J-10 combo). Declarer needs to knock out ♦A and ♦K. Hold up to strand the suit.

ATTACK TARGET: ≤3 cards or long without honours - safe for defenders to lead (e.g., 73, xxx, 8642, 9754)

- Defence: LEAD IT. When you need to switch, go here. This is your safe suit. Also the likely obvious shift suit for Granovetter signaling.
- *Example*: Dummy: ♠KJ95 ♥Q862 ♦A3 ♣742 → Clubs (742) are an ATTACK TARGET. No honours, 3 small. Switch here freely.

ENTRY SUIT: Contains A or K as a side entry to reach another suit (e.g., A3, Kx, AJ5, KQ4)

- Defence: ATTACK ENTRIES when dummy has a running/establishable suit elsewhere. Lead this suit to force out the entry prematurely. If you can remove all entries, the long suit is stranded.
- *Example*: Dummy: ♠74 ♥AKJ93 ♦853 ♣Q64 → Hearts are a RUNNING THREAT. But how does declarer reach them? ♥A and ♥K ARE the entries. If you force declarer to use hearts as entries (by ducking), the suit doesn't fully run.

TRUMP HOLDING: Dummy's trump length and shape - determines ruffing potential

- *Example*: Dummy: ♠Q83 ♥6 ♦KJ742 ♣A963 → 3 trumps + singleton heart = RUFFING VALUE. Lead trumps to cut heart ruffs. Diamonds are an ESTABLISHABLE SOURCE but secondary concern.

Dummy Profile

After classifying all 4 suits, write a one-sentence DUMMY PROFILE.

- **Dummy**: ♠754 ♥KQJ93 ♦A5 ♣842 → *Running threat in hearts, entry in diamonds (♦A), attack target in clubs, 3 trumps no ruffing value.* → **ACTIVE - hearts will run. Cash or attack the ♦A entry.**
- **Dummy**: ♠Q83 ♥942 ♦K63 ♣J1075 → *No threat suits, no entries worth attacking, flat dummy.* → **PASSIVE - declarer has no source of tricks in dummy. Don't break new suits.**
- **Dummy**: ♠6 ♥K1074 ♦QJ953 ♣A82 → *Singleton spade (ruffing value), establishable source in diamonds, entry in clubs (♣A).* → **ACTIVE - lead trumps to cut spade ruffs. Secondary: hold up in diamonds if possible.**
- **Dummy**: ♠AJ5 ♥73 ♦Q108742 ♣95 → *Establishable source in diamonds (6 cards!), entry in spades (♠A), attack targets in hearts and clubs.* → **ACTIVE - diamonds WILL run if declarer gets in. Attack the ♠A entry. If you lead spades, the entry is gone before diamonds are set up.**

Bidding Reconstruction

The auction is a conversation. Every bid tells you something about declarer's hand. Every PASS tells you something too. Before dummy appears, you should have a shape skeleton and HCP range. After dummy appears, refine it to near-certainty.

During the auction - before dummy appears

HCP RANGE: Opening bid constrains range: 1NT = 12-14, 1-suit = 12+, 2C = 22+. Each rebid narrows it: 1♥-2NT = 15-17 bal, 1♥-1♠-2♥ = 12-14 with 6 hearts, 1♥-1♠-3♥ = 15-17 with 6 hearts.

- 1NT-3NT → Declarer: 12-14, balanced. Dummy: 11-13 (invited or blasted).
- 1♥-2♥-4♥ → Declarer: 15-17 (jumped to game over single raise). Dummy: 6-9.
- 1♠-2♣-2♠ → Declarer: 12-14, 5+ spades, clubs not rebiddable. Minimum.
- 1♦-1♠-2NT → Declarer: 15-17, balanced, 4+ diamonds, denies 4 hearts or 4 spades.

SHAPE SKELETON: Bids show suits: 1♠ then 2♥ = 5+ spades, 4+ hearts. 1NT = balanced (no singleton, no 6-card suit). NEGATIVE INFERENCES (Reese's 'dog that didn't bark'): No Stayman = no 4-card major. No transfer = no 5-card major. Raised immediately = minimum for the raise, no side suit to show. Didn't rebid the suit = probably only 5 (not 6).

- 1♠-2♣-2♠ → 5-6 spades (rebid without jump = no extra values, just length). ≤3 hearts (didn't bid them). Clubs not rebiddable (probably 3). So roughly 5-2-3-3 or 6-2-3-2.
- 1♥-1♠-2♦-2NT-3NT → Opener: 4+ hearts, 4+ diamonds, 12-14 (didn't jump). Probably 1-4-4-4 or 2-4-4-3.
- (1♣)-1♠-(2♣)-(3♣)-3♠ → Overcaller: 5+ spades (overcall), minimum (didn't jump). Competitive, probably 5-3-3-2 or 5-4 somewhere.

TRICK ESTIMATE: Contract level = tricks needed. 3NT = 9, 4♥ = 10, 5♦ = 11. Count your sure tricks against this.

Dummy appears - refine the picture

HCP PINPOINT: 40 - your HCP - dummy's HCP = declarer + partner combined. Bidding narrows declarer's range → partner's range follows.

40 - 6 - 11 = 23 between declarer and partner. Auction was 1NT(12-14)-3NT → declarer has 12-14. Partner has 23 - (12 to 14) = 9-11 HCP.

→ Partner has an Ace and a King at minimum. You know roughly where the honours are.

SHAPE REFINEMENT: Dummy's shape is visible. Subtract from 13 to constrain declarer. Combined with the shape skeleton from the auction → near-complete picture.

Dummy: 3-3-3-4. Declarer opened 1♥ → 5+ hearts. Jumped to 4♥ over 2♥ → extras (15-17). With 5 hearts and extras: likely 5-3-3-2 or 5-4-2-2.

TRICK RECOUNT: Count dummy's sure tricks. Add declarer's expected tricks. Compare to contract. This is Kelsey's trick count - the most actionable of the three counts.

Five Lines of Defence

Dummy taxonomy + bidding reconstruction → one of five defence lines. Choose your line BEFORE playing to trick 1. Then execute consistently.

Line 1: RACE TO CASH

- When: Running threat in dummy + entries available. Declarer has enough tricks.
- Action: Cash your winners NOW. Don't try to establish - declarer will run before you.
- *Example*: 4♠ - Dummy: ♠74 ♥Q862 ♦AKQ93 ♣85 → Diamonds are a running threat with internal entries. Cash ♥AK immediately. Hope partner has a trick somewhere.

Line 2: ATTACK ENTRIES

- When: Establishable source in dummy + limited entries. Suit needs development.
- Action: Lead the entry suit to remove access BEFORE the long suit is established.
- *Example*: 3NT - Dummy: ♠653 ♥A4 ♦QJ10742 ♣83 → Diamonds are establishable (need ♦A knocked out). ♥A is the only entry. Win ♦A, then attack hearts (lead ♥J). If ♥A is gone before diamonds are set up, declarer can't reach them.

Line 3: PASSIVE DEFENCE

- When: Flat dummy, no threat suits, declarer is short of tricks.
- Action: Don't break new suits. Make declarer do the work. Return partner's lead or lead safe suits.
- *Example*: 3NT - Dummy: ♠Q83 ♥J74 ♦K63 ♣J1075 → Dummy is completely flat - no running suit, no entries worth attacking. Declarer has to find 9 tricks from nowhere. Lead passively, don't give free finesses. Every suit you break potentially gives declarer a trick they couldn't get alone.

Line 4: CUT THE RUFFS

- When: Dummy has trumps + singleton/void. Declarer plans to ruff losers.
- Action: Lead trumps at every opportunity. Each trump lead cuts one ruff.
- *Example*: 4♠ - Dummy: ♠Q83 ♥5 ♦KJ742 ♣A963 → Singleton heart + 3 trumps = ruffing value. Lead a trump. Win hearts later, lead another trump. Cut as many ruffs as possible.

Line 5: FORCE DECLARER

- When: You have 4+ trumps. Declarer has a two-suited hand.
- Action: Lead your longest side suit repeatedly. Force declarer to ruff, shortening their trumps below yours.
- *Example*: 4♥ - Dummy: ♠73 ♥KJ9642 ♦A5 ♣Q84 → You have 4 trumps! Force declarer to ruff spades. Lead ♠K, then ♠Q, then ♠J. If declarer ruffs three times, they have fewer trumps than you. Your ♥Q1083 scores extra tricks.

Decision Flowchart

- Is there a RUNNING THREAT in dummy? → Line 1 (RACE) or Line 2 (ATTACK ENTRIES)
- Is there an ESTABLISHABLE SOURCE? → Line 2 (ATTACK ENTRIES) - hold up and cut access
- Does dummy have ruffing value (short suit + trumps)? → Line 4 (CUT RUFFS)
- Do you have 4+ trumps? → Line 5 (FORCE DECLARER)
- Dummy is flat with no threats? → Line 3 (PASSIVE)

Worked Examples

Running threat - race to cash

Contract: 4♠ (1♠-2♦-3♠-4♠)

Your hand: ♠J6 ♥AK83 ♦1054 ♣Q972

Dummy: ♠Q74 ♥652 ♦AKQ93 ♣85

- ♠ TRUMP (3 cards, no short suit - no ruffing value)
- ♥ ATTACK TARGET (3 small)
- ♦ RUNNING THREAT (5 cards, AKQ - will produce 5 tricks)
- ♣ ATTACK TARGET (2 small)

Reconstruction: Auction: 1♠ = 5+ spades. 2♦ raised to 3♠ by partner (dummy). Dummy has 3 spades and AKQ diamonds - dummy bid 2♦ showing the source. Declarer: 5+ spades, some side values, accepted game try. Likely 5-3-2-3 or 5-4-1-3.

Trick count: Dummy's ♦AKQ = 3 tricks (declarer has 2 diamonds). Declarer's trumps = 5. ♠Q = 1 more. That's 9. Need 10. The 4th and 5th diamonds are the source.

Plan: ACTIVE - Line 1. Race to cash hearts. ♥A, then ♥K, then a heart to partner. Cash 3 hearts before diamonds run.

Result: ♥A, ♥K, ♥3 to partner's ♥Q. Partner cashes ♣A. Down 1.

Attack entries - strand the long suit

Contract: 3NT (1NT-3NT)

Your hand: ♠KQ1074 ♥J93 ♦A8 ♣K65

Dummy: ♠53 ♥A42 ♦Q109642 ♣83

- ♠ ATTACK TARGET (2 small - lead freely)
- ♥ ENTRY SUIT (♥A is the only side entry to diamonds)
- ♦ ESTABLISHABLE SOURCE (6 cards, Q-10-9 - needs ♦A and ♦K knocked out)
- ♣ ATTACK TARGET (2 small)

Reconstruction: 1NT-3NT: declarer 12-14 balanced. Dummy: weak hand with long diamonds, no major, just gambled 3NT. Declarer: 12-14 HCP, probably ♦Kx or ♦KJx. Balanced = no singleton.

Trick count: If diamonds come in: ♥A + 5 diamonds = 6. Declarer has 12-14 HCP = likely 2-3 more tricks. That's 8-9. Tight.

Plan: ACTIVE - Line 2. Lead ♠K (your suit). When you win ♦A, switch to ♥J to attack the ♥A entry. If hearts are removed before diamonds are established, the suit is stranded.

Result: ♠K lead, win 2 spades. Declarer leads ♦K - you duck! Declarer leads ♦J - win ♦A, switch to ♥J. ♥A is forced out. Declarer has 4 diamond tricks but only if they can reach dummy - they can't. Down 1.

Passive defence - flat dummy

Contract: 3NT (1♣-1♠-1NT-3NT)

Your hand: ♠1042 ♥Q963 ♦J85 ♣K72

Dummy: ♠KJ85 ♥J74 ♦Q63 ♣J105

- ♠ No threat (K-J with stoppers both sides)
- ♥ ATTACK TARGET (J-7-4, but leading into J is risky)
- ♦ No threat (Q-6-3, positional)
- ♣ No threat (J-10-5, positional)

Reconstruction: 1♣ = 4+ clubs. 1NT rebid = 12-14 balanced. Dummy bid 1♠ = 4+ spades, 6-13 HCP. Declarer: 12-14, balanced, 4+ clubs, denies 4 hearts (didn't bid them), denies 4 spades (rebid 1NT not 2♠). Probably 2-3-3-5 or 3-3-2-5 or 2-3-4-4.

Trick count: Dummy has no running suit. Declarer has clubs but no outside source. Count: ♣AQ (2), ♠A (1), ♦AK (2) = 5 sure tricks. Needs 4 more. Where from?

Plan: PASSIVE - Line 3. Declarer needs to develop 4 tricks from broken holdings. Every suit you break gives declarer a free finesse. Lead partner's suit if they bid, otherwise sit tight.

Result: Partner led ♦A then ♦K then ♦4. You play ♦J, ♦8, ♦5. Passive. Declarer struggles to find 9 tricks without help. Down 1.

Cut the ruffs - singleton in dummy

Contract: 4♥ (1♥-2♣-2♥-4♥)

Your hand: ♠A63 ♥K4 ♦KJ82 ♣Q1074
Dummy: ♠8 ♥Q10763 ♦A953 ♣A85
- ♠ Singleton = RUFFING VALUE (!!!)
- ♥ TRUMP (5 cards - strong support)
- ♦ No immediate threat (A-9-5-3, but ♦A is an entry)
- ♣ ENTRY SUIT (♣A provides access)

Reconstruction: 1♥ = 5+ hearts. 2♣ by dummy = 4+ clubs. 2♥ = minimum. 4♥ = dummy has game values with the fit. Declarer: 5+ hearts, 12-14, probably 4-5-2-2 or 3-5-2-3.

Trick count: Dummy has ♠ singleton → 2-3 spade ruffs if not stopped. Declarer's spade losers can disappear. With ♥Q10763 as trumps, each ruff is valuable.

Plan: ACTIVE - Line 4. Win ♠A at first opportunity, lead a trump. Win ♥K later, lead another trump. Cut the ruffs.

Result: Partner leads ♠K. You signal low (TSP - prefer lower suit = diamonds). Partner leads ♠Q, you overtake with ♠A. Lead ♥4 - cutting first ruff. Win ♥K later, lead ♥ again. Two ruffs cut. Down 1.

Force declarer - 4 trumps

Contract: 4♠ (1♠-2♠-4♠)
Your hand: ♠J1083 ♥4 ♦AKQ63 ♣J75
Dummy: ♠K74 ♥J9653 ♦72 ♣A84
- ♠ TRUMP (K-7-4 support)
- ♥ No threat (J-9-6-5-3, no outside honour to set up)
- ♦ ATTACK TARGET (7-2, you have AKQ!)
- ♣ ENTRY SUIT (♣A)

Reconstruction: 1♠ = 5+ spades. 2♠ = 6-9, 3+ spades. 4♠ = extras. Declarer: 15-17, 5+ spades. Likely ♠AQ9xx with ♥AKxx type.

Trick count: Declarer has ~5 spade tricks + ♥AK (2) + ♣A (1) = 8. Needs 2 more - will try to ruff diamonds or set up hearts.

Plan: ACTIVE - Line 5. You have 4 trumps (J-10-8-3). Force declarer! Lead ♦A, ♦K, ♦Q. Declarer must ruff. After 2 forces, declarer has fewer trumps than you. Your ♠J108 will score.

Result: ♦A, ♦K, ♦Q - declarer ruffs the third. Declarer draws 2 rounds of trumps but can't draw yours without running out. You score ♠J and ♠10. Down 1.

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Psychology - Competitive Protocols

Bridge is not purely mathematical - psychological tactics have a legitimate and critical role. Protocol-driven psychology converts book knowledge into table performance across four pillars: reading opponents, table presence, deception, and pressure management.

Reading Opponents

Card reading is logical deduction, not guesswork. Every bid, every card, every pass contains information - if you know how to read it. But bridge is played by humans, and humans leak information through tempo, emotion, body language, and behaviour. The expert reads ALL channels: cards, bids, non-bids, hesitations, posture, mood, and session momentum.

DIDD Method - Distribute, Infer, Decide, Do

- **Distribute** - Gather all clues from bidding, opening lead, and early play
- **Infer** - Construct a hypothesis about the unseen hands
- **Decide** - Test the hypothesis against further evidence as tricks are played
- **Do** - Choose the line consistent with the most likely layout

By trick 8-9, aim to know all four suit lengths for both defenders. Most bridge 'guesses' are not guesses at all - the available data has narrowed the layout to one or two possibilities.

Negative Inferences - The Dog That Did Not Bark

Inferences from what opponents chose NOT to do are as important as inferences from what they did. Every pass, every non-lead, every non-double is a statement about their hand.

Bidding Inferences:

- **Opponent didn't open the bidding** - Fewer than 12 HCP (usually). Narrows HCP range immediately.
- **Opponent overcalled but didn't lead his suit** - Likely lacks key honours in that suit - the overcall was for lead direction but the suit is too weak to lead
- **Opponent didn't raise partner's suit** - Likely fewer than 3 cards in support
- **Opponent didn't double for penalty** - Limited defensive strength - at most 1 trump trick
- **Opponent didn't bid 3NT with a balanced hand and stoppers** - Either unbalanced or lacks stopper - tells you about distribution
- **Opponent didn't preempt** - Doesn't have 7+ cards in any suit - more balanced than typical weak hand
- **Opponent passed partner's forcing bid** - System gap or minimum - but also places specific cards with the passing hand

Play Inferences:

- **Defender didn't cover your honour with their honour** - They don't have the honour above yours - place it with the other defender
- **Defender didn't return partner's suit after winning a trick** - Likely has a singleton/void in that suit, or found a better attack
- **Defender didn't signal encouragement in partner's suit** - Likely odd count (doubleton or void) or weak holding - plan accordingly
- **Defender didn't split their honours when you led toward dummy** - Either has only one honour or has length and is waiting
- **Declarer didn't draw trumps immediately** - Needs ruffs, or has a side suit to establish first - signals distribution

Reading Opponent Tempo

Opponent hesitations are legal to observe (not partner's). Tempo is the richest source of human information at the bridge table. A single hesitation can narrow a defender's hand to 2-3 possible holdings.

Bidding Tempo Tells:

- **Long pause before passing** - Had something to say - extra values or a borderline action. They're near the top of their range or had a competitive action they rejected.
- **Long pause before bidding** - Doubt about the action taken. The bid was close - they might have passed, or bid something different.
- **Snap bid (immediate action)** - Automatic - either very clear (strong hand) or pre-planned. No information about borderline holdings.
- **Long pause then pass over your preempt** - Had values but couldn't find a good call. Place them with 12-15 HCP and no clear suit to bid.
- **Quick pass of partner's opening bid** - Truly weak - didn't even consider responding. Likely < 6 HCP.
- **Hesitation before raising partner** - Borderline raise - minimum support or borderline strength. The raise is at the bottom of its range.

Play Tempo Tells:

- **Defender hesitates before following suit with a small card** - Had a choice - likely holds an honour in that suit they considered playing. Place the missing honour with them.
- **Defender plays quickly to trick 1** - Likely singleton or automatic play from a sequence. Low card fast = singleton or low from xx.
- **Defender hesitates at trick 1 then plays small** - Has the missing high card (Ace or King) and considered winning. Finesse away from them if possible.
- **Defender thinks before discarding** - Holds something worth keeping in multiple suits - distribution or honours revealed by what they're reluctant to release.
- **Declarer pauses at trick 1 before playing from dummy** - Declarer is planning - count winners/losers. Watch what they study in dummy: that's their problem suit.
- **Opponent plays a card then immediately picks up the next trick's cards** - Eager pace suggests confidence - they see a clear plan. Be more cautious with your defence.

Caution: ETHICAL OBLIGATION: never act on PARTNER's tempo. Only opponents' tempo is legal information. Be aware that strong opponents may use deliberate tempo deception - but this is rare at club level. Most tempo tells are genuine. The Laws of Bridge (Law 73) permit drawing inferences from opponents' tempo but prohibit acting on partner's.

Reading Opponent Emotions and Behaviour

Bridge players are emotional beings. Frustration, confidence, anxiety, and tilt leak through body language, pace of play, and bidding aggression. Reading these signals gives you a competitive edge that pure card reading misses.

Pre-Hand Reads:

- **Opponent picks up hand eagerly, sits up straighter** - Good hand incoming. Be prepared for aggressive bidding. Consider a light competitive action to disrupt.
- **Opponent glances at scorecard between boards** - Tracking the score - either winning (may get conservative) or losing (may get desperate). Both are exploitable.
- **Opponent sighs, slumps, or shakes head before bidding starts** - Bad hand or residual frustration from previous board. Tilt risk. Push harder in competitive auctions.
- **Opponents discuss the previous board before picking up cards** - Distracted. Not fully focused. Their first decision this board may be impulsive.
- **Opponent carefully sorts hand, counts points visibly** - Borderline hand. They're calculating whether to act. If they bid, they're at the bottom of the range.

Dummy Reactions:

- **Declarer's face falls when dummy comes down** - Dummy is worse than expected. Contract may be in trouble - defend actively, don't give away tricks.
- **Declarer brightens or relaxes when seeing dummy** - Dummy is better than expected or the contract is comfortable. Be aggressive on defence - tricks may disappear.
- **Declarer studies dummy for a long time** - Complex hand with a difficult plan. They're counting winners/losers. What they study longest is their key problem.
- **Declarer glances quickly at dummy and plays fast** - Either an easy hand (routine contract) or they've seen this position before. Standard technique will apply.

Mid-Play Reads:

- **Defender's posture shifts - leans forward or backward** - Engagement change. Leaning forward = key moment, they have a card to play. Leaning back = nothing left to contribute.
- **Opponent's tempo changes mid-hand - speeds up after being slow** - Decision made. They've figured out the position or given up on a suit. Their remaining plays are likely automatic.
- **Opponent makes a face or visible reaction to partner's card** - Surprised by partner's play. Possible defensive miscommunication. Their defence may be uncoordinated.
- **Opponent counts cards in their hand repeatedly** - Close hand. Counting is a stress response. They're near a critical decision. Apply time pressure by playing briskly.

Exploiting Opponent Frustration:

After a bad board, opponents are emotionally compromised for 2-3 boards. Frustration manifests as: overbidding to 'get the score back', underbidding from loss of confidence, impulsive doubles, or abandoning their system.

- After giving opponents a bottom: expect them to be aggressive on the next board. Be ready to double.
- If opponents argued during the previous board: their partnership trust is damaged. Compete harder - they'll misdefend.
- If an opponent made a visible error: they'll try to 'make up for it'. This usually means overbidding or taking anti-percentage lines.
- If opponents have been losing all session: by round 4-5, their judgement is degraded. Push marginal competitive decisions.
- NEVER exploit your own frustration. Apply the reset ritual instead.

Reading the Session Arc:

Opponents' play quality changes over the course of a session. Track the arc: fresh and sharp in round 1, potential fatigue or tilt by round 3-4, desperation or resignation in the final rounds.

- **Round 1-2** - Fresh, focused, disciplined - Play your system straight. Deception has lower success rate against fresh opponents.
- **Round 3-4** - Fatigue setting in. Accumulated frustration from bad boards possible. - Increase competitive aggression. Opponents make more errors in the middle of sessions.
- **Final rounds** - Tired, possibly tilted or resigned. Score-conscious pairs may panic-bid. - Maximum discipline. The field makes its worst decisions here. Solid play rises.
- **After a top against current opponents** - Demoralised. May overbid to compensate. - Conservative bidding, aggressive defence. Let them overreach.

Countering Opponents' Deception

Opponents false-card too. Recognising and neutralising their deception is as important as executing your own.

- **Pattern recognition:** Against habitual false-carders, their 'honest' plays become the tell. If they always false-card, the straight play IS the deception.
- **Count the hand:** A complete count makes deception impossible to sustain. If you know the distribution, a 'singleton' King from a player who bid the suit is obviously from KQ or Kx.
- **Bidding constraints:** The bidding constrains possible holdings. A player who opened 1NT can't have a singleton. A player who preempted can't have side-suit honours.
- **Play-bidding consistency:** Does the card played make sense given the bidding? If not, suspect deception. A defender who passed but drops the King probably doesn't have KQ.
- **Trust math:** Percentage plays overcome psychological traps. If the finesse is 68% and the drop is 32%, take the finesse regardless of the defender's false-card.

Table Presence

How you conduct yourself at the table affects opponents' decisions. Confidence projects strength. Calm unnerves the aggressive. Discipline frustrates the creative.

Half-a-Loaf Principle

Aim for the best result possible, not the best possible result. Secure consistent small wins rather than risking the contract for maximum gain. Even a quarter of potential points is better than nothing.

- When a greedy line risks the contract for an overtrick, prefer the safe line
- Take the sure plus rather than the speculative double
- Accept a quiet partscore rather than competing to a level you might not make

Opponent Archetype Recognition

Classify each opponent pair at the start of a round. Adjust strategy to exploit their predictable patterns.

- **Aggressive** - Overbids, competes aggressively, doubles readily - Let them overbid; be ready to double; avoid pushing them into sacrifices
- **Timid** - Underbids, sells out quickly, avoids doubles - Compete harder; steal partscores; they won't punish you
- **Tilted** - Emotional after bad boards, makes impulsive decisions - Apply maximum pressure; bid aggressively on marginal hands
- **Disciplined** - Consistent tempo, sound bidding, accurate play - Play your best bridge; deception has lower success rate; avoid gambles

Your Own Tempo Discipline

5-10 seconds per routine decision. Do not speed up with bad hands or slow down with good ones. Consistent tempo denies opponents free information and protects partnership ethics.

Deception

Deception is a legitimate competitive weapon - within the Laws and without misleading partner. The key is distinguishing free deception (always good) from costly deception (sometimes good).

Free vs Costly Deception

Free: Cannot cost a trick regardless of the layout. Example: dropping an honour from equals (Q from QJ, K from KQ when partner holds the A). Execute routinely.

Costly: Risks a trick to mislead. Example: ducking the Ace, leading from a tenace, false-carding with a unique card. Attempt only when the expected gain exceeds the risk.

- **Free** - Drop the Queen from QJ doubleton when partner leads the King - The Queen and Jack are equals - the false-card costs nothing
- **Free** - Win with the Ace (not the King) from AK when you want to conceal the King - You would win the trick with either card
- **Costly** - Duck the Ace at trick 1 to mislead declarer about its location - Declarer may not finesse again - you risk losing the trick entirely
- **Costly** - Lead the King from Kx to suggest a KQ holding - If partner reads it wrong, defence collapses

The Cardinal Rule of Deceptive Play

Deception must be spontaneous. It must be effected as though it were the perfectly normal and natural play - with neither undue haste nor undue deliberation. Pre-plan deceptive plays before the critical moment arrives.

- No hesitation - if you pause before false-carding, you telegraph the deception
- Pre-plan - decide your deceptive play during dummy's think time or before the hand begins
- Don't false-card every time - mix your plays to remain unpredictable
- Never mislead partner - deception targets opponents, not your own side

Reputation as a Weapon

A reputation for honest, disciplined play makes occasional deception devastating. Habitual false-carders become predictable - their 'honest' plays become the tell. The optimal frequency is low enough to maintain credibility but high enough to create doubt.

Standard Defensive Deceptive Positions

These ~13 positions recur frequently. Drill until recognition is automatic (< 2 seconds). Free positions should be executed every time.

#1 QJ from QJ doubleton [Free]: Drop the Queen - declarer may finesse the 10 next

- Holding: You: QJ, Dummy: K1092, Declarer leads toward dummy
- Standard: Play the Jack
- Why free: Q and J are equals; neither costs a trick

#2 Win high from AK [Free]: Win with the Ace - conceals the King's location

- Holding: You: AK(x), Declarer leads the suit
- Standard: Win with the King (standard)
- Why free: You win the trick either way

#3 Drop honour from equals under Ace [Free]: Play the Queen - declarer may place the Jack with partner

- Holding: Partner leads A (from AK), you hold QJ(x)
- Standard: Play the Jack (lowest of touching)
- Why free: Q and J are equals; you can spare either

#4 Smith Echo false count [Free]: Reverse your signal to mislead declarer about your attitude

- Holding: Any side suit on opening lead
- Standard: High-low = encouraging, low-high = discouraging
- Why free: Costs nothing if partner reads the position, not your card

#5 False count signal [Free (if partner reads position)]: Reverse the count signal to mislead declarer

- Holding: Following suit with a choice of small cards
- Standard: High-low = even count, low-high = odd count
- Why free: Partner should read count from the bidding + hand, not solely from the signal

#6 Duck the Ace [Costly]: Duck smoothly - declarer may finesse the wrong way next

- Holding: You: Axx(x), Declarer leads the suit
- Standard: Win the Ace
- Risk: Declarer may never play the suit again; you lose the Ace trick
- When: When declarer has a two-way finesse and you want to steer them wrong

#7 Drop the King from Kx [Costly]: Drop the King - declarer thinks it's singleton, finesses against partner next

- Holding: You: Kx, Dummy: Qxxx, Declarer plays the Ace
- Standard: Play small
- Risk: If declarer reads it as Kx, you've wasted the King

- When: When partner's Jxx will win a trick if declarer finesses the wrong way

#8 Lead the King from Kx (not KQ) [Costly]: Lead the King - suggests KQ sequence
- Holding: You: Kx on defence, leading through declarer
- Standard: Lead small
- Risk: Partner may duck with the Ace, thinking you have KQ
- When: Only when you can afford the confusion and need declarer to misjudge

#9 Smoothly play small from Kx behind dummy's AQJ [Costly]: Duck quickly - declarer may finesse the Queen, losing to partner
- Holding: Dummy: AQJ, You (behind dummy): Kx
- Standard: Cover or duck
- Risk: If declarer plays the Ace, your King is dead
- When: When declarer has a choice of finesses and you want to steer them away

#10 Split honours out of turn [Costly]: Split (play the higher honour) when you DON'T have to - suggests shortage
- Holding: You: KQ or QJ, Declarer leads toward dummy
- Standard: Play small if possible
- Risk: Wastes an honour trick
- When: When you want declarer to miscount the suit or misread your distribution

#11 False-card the ten from 10xx [Free]: Drop the 10 - declarer may misread as doubleton
- Holding: You: 10xx, Partner leads high (K or A), Dummy: Jxxx
- Standard: Play low (count signal)
- Why free: The 10 has no trick-taking potential in this layout

#12 Win with unnecessary high card (overtake) [Free]: Overtake with the King - suggests a different honour layout to declarer
- Holding: Partner leads the Queen, you hold AK
- Standard: Encourage with a high spot
- Why free: You hold both honours; overtaking costs nothing

#13 Delayed duck [Costly]: Win on the SECOND round (not third) - makes declarer think you ducked once with Ax
- Holding: You: Axx in dummy's long suit (NT defence)
- Standard: Win the Ace immediately
- Risk: If declarer can switch suits, you may not get the Ace trick
- When: When you want declarer to miscount the suit and play a third round into your Ace

Standard Declarer Deceptive Positions

These ~8 positions are declarer's deceptive toolkit. Unlike defender deception, declarer deception targets both defenders simultaneously.

#1 Win high to conceal length [Free]: Win with the Ace - conceal the King
- Holding: You: AKx(x), Defenders lead the suit
- Why free: You win the trick either way
- Effect: Defenders may think partner has the King and continue the suit

#2 Lead toward weakness [Free]: Lead small toward dummy's Queen as if you hold the King
- Holding: You: xxx, Dummy: Qxx
- Why free: You'd lead toward the Queen anyway as a normal finesse attempt
- Effect: Left-hand defender may not cover with the King, or may waste the Ace

#3 Steal a trick early [Costly]: At trick 2, lead a low card toward dummy's King
- Holding: Dummy: Kx, Defender behind dummy has the Ace
- Risk: If the Ace takes, no deception; if it ducks, you steal a trick
- Effect: Works best early when defenders haven't counted tricks

#4 Tempo deception (snap play) [Free]: Play quickly on hard decisions to project confidence
- Holding: Any difficult decision
- Why free: Tempo costs nothing
- Effect: Defenders second-guess their defence when declarer appears confident

#5 Fake ruff attempt [Costly]: Lead the side suit as if attempting to ruff in dummy
- Holding: Side suit you don't need to ruff
- Risk: Defenders may lead trumps (which you wanted) or may not be fooled
- Effect: Defenders waste a trump lead; or continue the wrong suit

#6 False discard [Costly]: Discard a card from the suit you want to run, suggesting weakness
- Holding: Long suit you want to keep, short suit that looks like a discard
- Risk: You weaken your actual suit
- Effect: Defenders attack the wrong suit or fail to hold up

#7 Finesse into the 'wrong' hand [Costly]: Finesse into the hand that DOESN'T have the dangerous shift
- Holding: Two-way finesse available
- Risk: The finesse may lose
- Effect: Even if it loses, the defender on lead can't damage you

#8 Duck in dummy at trick 1 [Free (when automatic)]: Duck smoothly - LHO may shift, saving your King
- Holding: Dummy: Kx, LHO leads Ace (from AQ)
- Why free: The King would lose to the Ace anyway
- Effect: LHO may think partner has the King and shift suits

Pressure Management

Managing your own psychology and exploiting opponents' emotional state is a core competitive skill.

Have/Have-Not Dynamic

When you hold strong cards (HAVE): play constructive, accurate bridge. When you hold weak cards (HAVE-NOT): deploy psychological weapons - obstruction, deception, harassment. The best players seamlessly transition between both roles.

Opponents hold good cards roughly 50% of the time. Making a game by deception counts exactly as much as making it by brute force.

Reset Ritual

- After a bad board: deep breath, 5 seconds of silence
- Clear the mind: the last board does not exist
- Treat the next board as if the session just started
- Never discuss results mid-session - save all analysis for post-mortem

One bad board becomes three when frustration infects decision-making. The reset breaks the cascade.

Session Momentum

Track your emotional state, not just the boards. After a string of bad boards, opponents often loosen - exploit this with precise, aggressive play. After a string of good boards, guard against overconfidence.

Treat the last 5 boards as a new session. T1-T4 data shows consistent second-half improvement when closing discipline is maintained.

Decision Trees

Should I false-card here?

- Is it free (from equals)? → YES, always
- Is it costly? → Check: will declarer/opponent likely take a specific line without the false-card?
- If yes: does the false-card redirect them to a losing line? → YES, attempt with smooth tempo
- If no: the false-card gains nothing → PASS
- Can you execute without hesitation? → If not, DON'T - a telegraphed false-card is worse than none

What do I know about the unseen hands?

- Step 1: HCP count - 40 minus (your hand + dummy + any shown cards)
- Step 2: Distribution - track cards played in each suit
- Step 3: Negative inferences - what didn't opponents do?
- Step 4: Tempo - any hesitations from opponents?
- Step 5: Construct hypothesis → test against next trick → decide

Am I tilted?

- Did the last board go badly? → Execute reset ritual before picking up cards
- Am I thinking about a previous board? → YES, you're tilted - reset
- Am I making decisions faster than usual? → Slow down to standard 5-10 second tempo
- Am I considering a line I wouldn't normally play? → Check: is this bold or reckless?

Common Errors

- **1** - Telegraphing the false-card - Pre-plan deceptions during dummy think time. If you can't be smooth, don't attempt it
- **2** - Ignoring negative inferences - After every auction, ask: what did they NOT bid? What does that tell me?
- **3** - Playing the same way against all opponents - Classify opponents at round start. Adjust your competitive threshold
- **4** - Greedy play (anti-Half-a-Loaf) - Ask: what do I gain vs what do I lose? If the loss is larger, take the safe line
- **5** - Tilt cascade - letting one bad board infect the next - Execute the reset ritual. Every single time. No exceptions

Worked Examples

Reading Opponents - Counterintuitive Trump Attack (T4, Board 14) (Reading Opponents)

Contract: E 3♠ | *Result:* Down 1 - NS +50 (TOP)

Scenario: East opens with 6 spades + club void. Standard defence leads a club or heart. But DIDD reveals the danger: East's void means ruff potential.

Psychology applied: NEGATIVE INFERENCE: East didn't bid 4♠ - limited strength despite shape. DIDD: Distribute East's cards - 6 spades + void = extreme shape. The danger is ruffs, not brute force. DECIDE: attack trumps with ♠J to shorten East's trumps before the void becomes useful. DO: ♠J lead.

Lesson: The field led 'normal' suits and gave East ruffs. Psychology pillar (reading) + Intelligence pillar (counting distribution) combined to find the only defence that beats the contract.

Half-a-Loaf - Penalty Defence Beats Declaring (T3, Board 12) (Table Presence)

Contract: E 3♥ doubled | *Result:* Down 4 - NS +800 (TOP)

Scenario: East opened weak, raised to 3♥. Partner doubled (takeout). You hold ♥AK84. Could declare 4♠ or pass for penalty.

Psychology applied: HALF-A-LOAF: +800 (penalty) vs +620 (making game) vs -100 (game goes down). The safe defence is the CERTAIN result; declaring is speculative. ARCHETYPE: East is desperate (weak preemptor pushed to 3♥) - likely going down multiple tricks. DECIDE: pass for penalty.

Lesson: The greedy play (declaring) risks -100. The safe play (defending) gets +800. Half-a-Loaf says take the sure plus. The field bid and scored +620 at best. Discipline > brilliance.

Exploiting Opponent Tilt - Passive Lead from Shaken Pair (T4, Board 16) (Pressure Management)

Contract: S 2♠ +2 | *Result:* NS +170 (TOP)

Scenario: Round 4 - opponents have had a bad session. Previous board was a disaster for them. East leads ♠8 into your ♠AQJ - a passive, unfocused lead that gifts a trick.

Psychology applied: FRUSTRATION READ: opponents discussed previous board before picking up cards - distracted. ARCHETYPE: tilted pair, impulsive decisions likely. SESSION ARC: Round 4, opponents degraded. EXPLOIT: won the ♠ cheaply, ran clubs, collected +170 when the field conceded -140.

Lesson: Opponents' emotional state directly affected their lead quality. A focused pair leads a club or diamond. A tilted pair leads passively into declarer's strength. Read the mood, not just the cards.

Negative Inference in Defence - Elite Trick Extraction (T2, Board 6) (Reading Opponents)

Contract: E 4♥ | *Result:* Down 1 - NS +100 (TOP)

Scenario: DD analysis says 4♥ makes 10 tricks at every other table. Only our table beat 4♥. South holds ♥AJ - the defensive holding.

Psychology applied: NEGATIVE INFERENCE: Declarer didn't draw trumps immediately - needs side-suit tricks first. This means declarer's trumps are not solid. DIDD: track the play; declarer's ♥ holding is KQ10xxx with a finesse position. Partner's count signal shows even length. DECIDE: hold up the ♥A to force declarer to misguess the position. DO: duck the first heart, win the second, cash side winners.

Lesson: Card reading via negative inference (declarer's tempo, non-actions) found the only defence. The field's defenders played automatically; our defenders read the position.

Free Deception - Defender False-Card from Equals (Deception)

Contract: S 3NT | *Result:* Representative position

Scenario: Declarer leads small spade toward dummy's K1092. You hold ♠QJ3. Standard play is the Jack (bottom of touching). Deceptive play is the Queen.

Psychology applied: FREE DECEPTION: Q and J are equals - playing the Q costs nothing. CARDINAL RULE: play the Q smoothly, without hesitation. EFFECT: declarer may place the Jack with East and finesse the 10 on the next round, losing to your J. If you played the J, declarer covers with K, then finesses the 10 - your Q falls under the K and 10 scores.

Lesson: This is position #1 from the Defender Catalogue. Free, automatic, no risk. The hesitation-free drop of the Q is more effective than the 'correct' J. Drill until this is automatic.

Additional Materials - Hand Evaluation

High Card Points are the lingua franca of bridge, but HCP alone misjudge distributional hands, honour placement, and fit quality. A complete evaluation combines HCP with distributional adjustments, Losing Trick Count, controls, working honours, and suit quality.

Milton Work Point Count

- **Ace** - 4
- **King** - 3
- **Queen** - 2
- **Jack** - 1

Total deck: **40** HCP.

Guidelines

opening: 12+ HCP (or Rule of 20)
game major: ~25 combined HCP with 8+ fit
game minor: ~28-29 combined HCP
game nt: ~25 combined HCP with stoppers
slam small: ~33 combined HCP
slam grand: ~37 combined HCP
Treats all aces as equal - A opposite KQJ is better than A opposite xxx
Ignores distribution entirely
Overvalues unsupported honours (singleton K, doubleton Q)
Ignores intermediates (tens, nines)

Distributional Adjustments

Distribution creates tricks beyond HCP. There are two schools: length points (Goren original) count long suits before a fit is found; shortness points (Karpin/Bergen) count short suits after a fit is found. Both capture the same truth: shape generates tricks.

Length Points (Goren)

Add 1 point per card beyond four in any suit

- **5-card suit** - 1
- **6-card suit** - 2
- **7-card suit** - 3

Shortness Points (Dummy Points)

When raising partner's suit, add points for shortness

- **Void** - 5
- **Singleton** - 3
- **Doubleton** - 1

Warning: *Do not count shortness points when you are the declarer or when the short suit contains wasted honours (Qx, Jx).*

Bergen's Rule of 20

Add HCP + length of two longest suits. If total >= 20, open the bidding.

- **♠:AQxxx ♥:KJxxx ♦:Jx ♣:x** - 11 - 5+5=10 - 21 - Open
- **♠:AQxx ♥:KJx ♦:Qxx ♣:xxx** - 12 - 4+3=7 - 19 - Pass (flat shape, poor controls)

Working vs Wasted Honours

Honours in partner's suits and in your long suits generate tricks. Honours in short suits or in opponent's suits are wasted.

- **Honour in partner's suit** - +1 (the honour is working)
- **Honour in opponent's bid suit** - -1 (likely not pulling weight on offense)
- **Singleton honour (K, Q, J alone)** - -2 (cannot develop tricks, may be captured)
- **Doubleton honour (Qx, Jx)** - -1 (needs partner's help to be worth anything)
- **Aces and Kings** - Always working - they take tricks regardless

Control Count

- **Ace** - 2
- **King** - 1

An average hand has 4 controls. Hands with 5+ controls are slam-oriented; hands with 3 or fewer are defensive.

The Italian school (Blue Team) valued controls over HCP for slam bidding. A hand with 14 HCP but only 2 controls (two kings, no aces) is dangerous at the 5-level. A hand with 12 HCP and 5 controls (two aces + one king) is a powerful slam hand.

Honour Combinations and Intermediates

Honours working together generate tricks. AKQ in one suit is worth more than A, K, Q spread across three suits. Intermediates (T, 9) fill out suits and prevent losers.

- **AKJTx** - Almost certainly 5 tricks - the T fills beautifully
- **AKxxx** - Only 3 sure tricks - needs 3-2 break for 4
- **QJT9x** - Self-sufficient opposite any doubleton - 3 tricks likely
- **Qxxxx** - Generates tricks only with partner's help

Suit Quality Test (SQT)

SQT = suit length + number of honour cards (A, K, Q, J, T) in the suit

A suit is biddable at the N-level if SQT >= N + number of tricks you need. Useful for overcalls, preempts, and competitive decisions.

- **KQJ9xxx** - 11 - SQT 11 - strong enough for a 3-level preempt at any vulnerability
- **Qxxxxx** - 7 - SQT 7 - marginal for a 2-level weak two; fine at favorable
- **AKJTx** - 9 - SQT 9 - excellent 5-card overcall suit
- **Jxxxx** - 6 - SQT 6 - do not overcall with this suit

Adjust-3 (Quick Revaluation)

After a fit is found, add 1 point for each trump beyond the eighth, add 1 for a side singleton, add 1 for a side void, and subtract 1 for each flat-hand indicator (4333).

Playing Tricks vs Defensive Tricks

A hand has playing tricks (tricks it can take as declarer) and defensive tricks (tricks it can take defending). Distributional hands have many playing tricks but few defensive. Balanced hands have defensive tricks but limited playing tricks.

- Aces and kings are both playing and defensive
- Long suits add playing tricks but not defensive
- Queens and jacks in short suits add defensive tricks but not playing
- Voids add playing tricks (via ruffs) but zero defensive

This distinction matters in competitive auctions. When deciding 'bid or double', count your defensive tricks. If you have 2 or fewer defensive tricks, bidding is usually right. If you have 4+, doubling pays better.

Evaluation Tools Summary

- **HCP** - Opening bids, NT ranges, first approximation - Ignores distribution
- **Distributional points** - Suit contracts, revaluation after fit - Meaningless in NT
- **Rule of 20** - Marginal opening decisions - Doesn't account for vulnerability or seat
- **Working honours** - Revaluation during the auction - Requires information from bidding
- **Controls** - Slam evaluation - Ignores suit quality
- **SQT** - Overcalls, preempts, competitive bids - Suit-specific, not whole-hand
- **Losing Trick Count** - Suit contracts, competitive decisions, slam tries - Unreliable in NT; assumes a trump fit

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Additional Materials - Losing Trick Count

The Losing Trick Count evaluates hand strength by counting losers - cards that will not win tricks even in the best case. It is more accurate than HCP for suit contracts, especially for distributional hands and competitive decisions. The formula: 24 minus combined losers equals the number of tricks the partnership can expect.

How to Count Losers

Examine only the top three cards in each suit. Each missing top honour (Ace, King, Queen) in the top three is one loser. A void has 0 losers. A singleton has at most 1 loser. A doubleton has at most 2 losers.

- **Void** - 0
- **Singleton** - 1
- **Doubleton** - 2
- **3+ cards** - 3

Standard LTC - Losers per Holding

- **-** - 0 - Void
- **A** - 0 -
- **K** - 1 - Singleton K counts as 1 (may be captured)
- **Q** - 1 - Singleton Q counts as 1 (usually lost)
- **x** - 1 - Small singleton
- **AK** - 0 -
- **AQ** - 0.5 - Half loser (finesse dependent)
- **Ax** - 1 -
- **KQ** - 1 -
- **Kx** - 1 -
- **Qx** - 2 - Very likely both lost without help
- **xx** - 2 -
- **AKQ** - 0 -
- **AKx** - 1 -
- **AQx** - 1 - Half loser rounded up; finesse for Q
- **Axx** - 2 -
- **KQx** - 1 -
- **Kxx** - 2 -
- **Qxx** - 2.5 - The queen rarely takes a trick without support
- **xxx** - 3 - Maximum losers for any holding

Combined Loser Count → Expected Tricks

24 minus (opener's losers + responder's losers) = expected tricks

- **7** - 9 - 16 - 8 - 2-level (partscore)
- **7** - 7 - 14 - 10 - 4-level (game in major)
- **5** - 7 - 12 - 12 - 6-level (small slam)
- **4** - 7 - 11 - 13 - 7-level (grand slam)

Cover Cards

A cover card is a card that covers one of partner's losers - typically an ace or king in the right suit. When partner opens and you hold fitting honours, count cover cards rather than HCP to decide whether to bid game or slam.

Partner opens 1♠ showing 5+ spades. You hold ♠:Kxxx ♥:Axx ♦:Qxxx ♣:xx (9 HCP, 9 losers). Count cover cards for partner's likely hand: the ♠:K covers one spade loser, the ♥:A covers a heart loser - 2 cover cards. If partner has 7 losers, combined = 14 - 2 = 12 tricks? No - the loser count method is more accurate. 24 - (7+9) = 8 tricks. But if partner's 7-loser hand has specific losers in hearts and spades, your covers are perfectly placed.

Typical Loser Count by Common Bidding Actions

- **Open at the 1-level** - 7 (range 5-8)
- **Minimum response (6-9 HCP)** - 9-10
- **Invitational raise (10-12)** - 8

- **Game-forcing response (12+)** - 7 or fewer
- **Preemptive opening (weak two)** - 8-9
- **Preemptive opening (3-level)** - 8-9 (7+ card suit)
- **Strong 2♣ opening** - 4-5
- **Strong 2♦ opening (game force)** - 3-4
- **Overcall (simple)** - 7-8
- **Takeout double** - 6 (shape compensates)

Ron Klinger's Queen Adjustments

Standard LTC overvalues queens. Klinger suggested adjustments: a guarded queen (Qxx+) in a bid suit is worth half a loser less; a singleton or doubleton queen is worth nothing.

- **Qxx+ in partner's bid suit** - Subtract 0.5 losers
- **Qxx+ in your own long suit** - Subtract 0.5 losers
- **Singleton Q** - Count as 1 full loser (same as singleton x)
- **Doubleton Qx** - Count as 2 losers (queen is unlikely to take a trick)

New Losing Trick Count (Koelman)

NLTC refines the standard count by weighting losers: an ace loser (missing the ace) costs more than a queen loser (missing the queen), because aces take tricks independently while queens need support.

- **Ace** - 1.5
- **King** - 1.0
- **Queen** - 0.5

26 minus combined NLTC losers = expected tricks

Reliability and Limitations

Works well for:

- Suit contracts with an 8+ card trump fit
- Competitive decisions (bid vs pass vs double)
- Slam exploration in suit contracts
- Evaluating distributional hands that HCP undervalue

Unreliable for:

- Notrump contracts (distribution doesn't generate ruffs)
- Misfits (no 8-card fit; losers don't cancel)
- Very short suits opposite very long suits (duplication)
- Hands where the opponents' lead kills a critical entry

LTC vs HCP Decision Guide

- **Opening the bidding** - HCP (Rule of 20 for borderline) - LTC requires a fit to be meaningful
- **Raising partner's suit** - LTC - Fit is confirmed; LTC measures playing strength
- **Notrump bidding** - HCP - LTC assumes ruffs; NT relies on high cards and stoppers
- **Competitive decisions** - LTC - Distributional hands overbid by LTC less than by HCP
- **Slam investigation** - LTC (NLTC for precision) - Controls and playing tricks matter, not scattered queens
- **Penalty doubles** - HCP + defensive tricks - You need quick tricks, not playing tricks